Still Releasing

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/85590191.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Swift Wind | Spirit, Adora & Entrapta (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Identity Crisis, Psychological Drama, POV Adora (She-Ra), Post-Canon, Existential Crisis, Angst with a Happy Ending, Introspection, Character Study, Trauma, Recovery, Healing, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Protective Catra (She-Ra), Soft Catra (She-Ra), Tenderness, Emotional Intimacy, Anxiety, Planet Etheria (She-Ra), Shame, Magic, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Adora-centric (She-Ra), Unreliable Narrator, Dissociation, Flashbacks, Self-Worth Issues, Communication Failure, Hurt Adora (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2026-05-26 Completed: 2026-08-25 Words: 30,122 Chapters: 14/14

Still Releasing

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/85590191.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Swift Wind | Spirit, Adora & Entrapta (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Identity Crisis, Psychological Drama, POV Adora (She-Ra), Post-Canon, Existential Crisis, Angst with a Happy Ending, Introspection, Character Study, Trauma, Recovery, Healing, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Protective Catra (She-Ra), Soft Catra (She-Ra), Tenderness, Emotional Intimacy, Anxiety, Planet Etheria (She-Ra), Shame, Magic, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Adora-centric (She-Ra), Unreliable Narrator, Dissociation, Flashbacks, Self-Worth Issues, Communication Failure, Hurt Adora (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2026-05-26 Completed: 2026-08-25 Words: 30,122
Chapters: 14/14

Still Releasing

by NotMyDestiny

Summary

Adora saved the universe, defeated Horde Prime, and finally has the life she always wanted with Catra. So why is peace so hard?

As Etheria's restored magic settles across the planet, everything begins to grow, wake, and change in ways no one fully understands. Everyone else sees healing. Adora sees questions she can't seem to answer.

With the war over and no clear evil left to fight, she begins to wonder about her own goodness, the weight of power, and how easily a right choice might become the wrong one. Catra tries to keep her grounded, but Adora can't tell whether healing is supposed to feel like this.

Chapter 1: Peace

Morning light gathered in the chipped edges of the balcony tiles before it touched anything whole. It came in slowly, settling first in the pale seams where old stone had cracked and been fitted back together and in the shallow scratches left by weather and war. It stretched across each uneven line as if the room had been made to hold this kind of unguarded quiet.

Adora opened her eyes. Catra was pressed against her side. Her breathing came slow and deep, each exhale brushing warmly over Adora's cheek. One hand had found Adora's wrist in sleep and curled there, loose but certain. The fragrant scent of distant blossoms was cloyingly sweet.

The windows were open. The world had not ended in the night. Everything was fine. The thought wouldn't settle.

Adora shifted carefully, barely enough to move the sheet. Catra's fingers tightened for one drowsy second around her wrist, then loosened again without waking. Adora's chest softened at the gesture.

Adora wanted to stay there, with Catra asleep beside her and Bright Moon whole enough beyond the balcony. She wanted to let the morning hold.

The soft rushing of the waterfalls filled the room. They seemed too close today. The sound pressed in, bright and endless and unconcerned with whether she was ready for it.

Catra shifted against her, ear flicking once. "You're thinking too hard dummy," she mumbled affectionately. Her thumb moved once over the inside of Adora's wrist. "You're lying there like the fate of Etheria depends on your jaw clenching."

Adora exhaled, the rushing receded. Her chest loosened slightly. "I'm just lying still," she said. "That's a normal thing people do.

People lie still all the time.”

“Okay.”

“That’s it?”

Catra shifted closer, pulling herself up partway, dragging the blanket with her as if the entire bed belonged to her. Her expression was caught between concern and the laziness of early morning. “You want me to interrogate you?”

“No.”

“Because I can. I have ways.”

“You have claws.”

“And excellent instincts.” Catra tucked her face against Adora's shoulder.

The teasing landed lightly. A playful smile curled across Adora’s face. “You’re very smug for someone who drooled on the pillow.”

“Lies.”

Adora laughed, small and unplanned. Catra's arm tightened, briefly, and Adora let herself be held, let herself press back into the warmth of it, Catra solid and present, the smell of her familiar enough to feel steady. “There’s evidence.”

“You planted it.”

“While lying completely still?”

“You’re She-Ra. You have powers.”

Adora’s smile flickered.

The words were harmless. It was the kind of joke that should have landed easily, should have become just another piece of a familiar morning, but the name caught somewhere under Adora’s

ribs. She-Ra. Power as answer. Power as assurance. Power as proof that nothing could go too wrong if she was there to stop it.

Catra's expression shifted, awake enough now to understand that the joke had touched something real.

"Hey." Catra curled her tail around Adora's ankle. "You don't have to solve anything right now. You're here with me. That's all I need."

Something in Adora wanted to believe that so badly it hurt. She turned her head toward the balcony before Catra could look too closely.

Outside, the light had reached the upper leaves of the garden. Everything beyond was washed in a green-gold shimmer, alive with small motions. Vines had climbed another finger's width along the balcony rail overnight, their new leaves unfurling in delicate spirals. The water kept rushing.

Adora could feel Catra's careful attention beneath the sleepy teasing. Catra had always been good at noticing the things Adora tried to bury under useful words, too good, sometimes. It made Adora want to reach for something solid, an explanation or reason that would make the feeling behave.

"It's stupid. I'm happy," Adora said, which was true and somehow not enough. She tried to laugh, but it came out thin. "It's just… quiet."

Catra's ears shifted.

"Not bad quiet," Adora added quickly. "Just quiet."

For a moment, Catra said nothing. Then she shrugged with one shoulder, still tucked against Adora's side. "Yeah," she said. "Quiet's weird."

Adora looked back at her.

Catra’s mouth twitched. “Don’t tell anyone I said that, though. I have a reputation to maintain.”

Adora smiled again for real. Catra saw it, of course she did. Her mouth tilted in satisfaction, like she had won something, then she reached across the narrow space between them and pushed a strand of hair back from Adora’s forehead. Her claws grazed lightly over Adora’s temple, careful as breath. The touch was grounding in its simplicity.

…

The morning had come fully into itself by the time Adora moved through Bright Moon's outer corridors, light coming in long and golden through the arches, catching the crystals in the walls so they threw soft color across the stone. Magic hummed through the pathways, vibrating through the soles of her boots. She had no particular direction. She had a whole day with no particular direction, which was, she had been told, several times, by several people who loved her, a good thing.

She looked out beyond the courtyard wall. Far off, above the lower terraces, a line of winged creatures moved across the bright sky. They were too distant to make out clearly, only dark shapes passing through light, but they shifted together with eerie precision. They weren’t birds or anything Adora knew by name.

They were returning, someone would probably say. Etheria’s sleeping creatures and magic restored. Everyone had said words like that a lot since the war. They had said them with relief and hope and tired smiles over planning tables and crates and rubble. Etheria was healing. The planet was waking. Magic was settling.

The reconstruction had left repairs everywhere. There was fresh mortar, regrown crystal, replaced railings. Everyone called it rebuilt. Adora could still see how close it had come to collapse.

Something rustled near the base of the wall. A tiny blue lizard with six legs and feathered ears and a shimmering back. It

chirped once, then vanished into a crack that immediately sealed behind it with a bloom of moss. Adora stared.

The moss pulsed once. Adora's hand twitched as if to summon her sword. Then nothing happened. The wall remained a wall. Somewhere inside it, the lizard chirped again, soft and indignant.

She should tell Bow about that. He would want to know. Bow would make notes and ask whether the lizard had seemed distressed or curious or magical. Glimmer would say this was exactly why they needed an official council role for post-Heart ecological phenomena. Catra would say the wall lizard had the right idea and more people should disappear from conversations whenever they wanted.

Adora smiled despite herself. Then the smile faded because for one brief second, she had known what to do. She'd find Bow, report the lizard, make things useful, turn the strangeness into information and a plan. The urge was so familiar that it left an ache behind when she resisted it.

This was supposed to be a walk, just a day with no proving anything. She was not supposed to turn a lizard into a mission just because reporting something made her feel like she existed correctly. Maybe it did not need to be understood before it was allowed to just live.

Adora stared at the moss where it had disappeared. Was continuing to walk a good choice? Was ignoring it irresponsible? Was reporting it better or paranoid? There had to be a correct answer. There had always been a correct answer, hadn't there? If she couldn't tell the difference, what did that say about her?

She rubbed both hands over her face. "It was a lizard," she whispered.

A passing gardener glanced over.

Adora straightened too fast. "Hi."

The gardener smiled. “Good morning, She-Ra.”

Adora almost stepped backward into a planter. “Hi. I mean, good morning. And, um, Adora is fine. I mean, She-Ra is also fine. Both are fine.”

The gardener’s smile warmed. “Good morning, Adora.”

He kept walking, basket of cut stems balanced against one hip, as if she had not nearly lost a battle with basic conversation. Adora exhaled. She pressed both hands to her face. Great, she thought, very normal, extremely heroic.

She tried again to focus on her walk. Just name the beauty. That was something Perfuma had told her once, gently, after a meeting where Adora had spent twenty minutes turning a report about restored plants into a tactical risk assessment.

Adora gave it a try. Purple moss was almost iridescent in the light on the left wall. New cracks in the stone were filled in with glittering gold roots.

Was the moss spreading too quickly? Were the roots repairing the wall or weakening it?

Adora shut her eyes.

Perfuma made it sound easy. Name the beauty and just let it be beauty. Adora had spent too long looking for weak points and anything that might break if she looked away.

She opened her eyes and started walking again. She did not know what the walk was for or whether she was doing it right, but moving still felt enough like purpose to borrow, so she kept going.

…

Dinner was loud which helped. Adora let it move around her, the clatter of dishes, Bow’s laughter, Glimmer’s complaining, and Catra’s knee pressed against hers beneath the table. For a while,

she only had to pass the bread when Bow reached for it, to roll her eyes at Catra's snark about her mandated service work, to listen while Glimmer described the exact expression on a visiting councilor's face when one of the newly returned migrating creatures had landed on the meeting table and eaten the corner of a trade agreement.

"So," Bow said, reaching for the bowl of roasted moonroot, "what did you do with your first completely free day?"

Adora opened her mouth. The question should have been simple.

Catra glanced at her, one brow lifting with quiet amusement, but there was softness under it too.

"I walked around," Adora said, and heard how empty it sounded. No one had needed her. No one had been safer because of her. There was nothing to point to and show she had done the right thing, nothing that could be held up afterward as evidence. She almost wanted to add that it was unproductive, but she caught herself before she did.

"That's good," Glimmer said. She said it plainly, without making it sound like an achievement, which somehow made it harder to hold.

Adora waited for the rest of the question. Who needed help? What went wrong?

Glimmer only reached for the bread.

Bow smiled. "That sounds nice, actually. You notice anything interesting?"

Interesting how?" Adora asked before she could stop herself. "Like… tactically?"

Bow's expression softened. "No. Just interesting." He said it gently, like he knew exactly how hard the difference was.

Adora thought of the lizard, the shimmer on its back and the clean relief of almost having something to report. “Flowers,” she said. “And the vines by the eastern wall.”

Catra’s knee pressed more firmly against hers.

Adora looked up. Catra was listening to Bow, chin propped on her hand, expression bored in a way that fooled no one. Her tail curled around Adora’s ankle like a tether. Adora breathed, and the relief lasted through dessert.

It was late by the time they got back to their room. Catra fell asleep quickly, in the total, boneless way she only managed when she felt safe. She curled on her side, one hand tucked under the pillow, ears relaxed, mouth softened out of its usual guarded line. Moonlight replaced the morning gold, laying pale light along her cheek and shoulder. The waterfalls whispered.

Adora lay beside her and watched. There had been a time when Catra sleeping near her would have felt impossible. Now Catra slept within reach, trusting Adora with all the unguarded pieces of herself.

Catra trusted her. Glimmer trusted her. Bow trusted her. Etheria had trusted her. The whole planet had opened around her power and survived because, at the final moment, she had reached for love.

What happened now when there was no single terrible machine to destroy, no clean line between saving and harming? Adora looked at Catra’s sleeping hand. How could she be sure she would do the right things to protect this?

She slipped out of bed carefully. Catra shifted, making a small sound, then settled again. Adora crossed to the balcony. Cool air moved over her face.

The night smelled of clean stone and distant blossoms. Below, Bright Moon glowed in layers of silvery blue. The waterfalls

poured endlessly into mist. Vines shivered along the walls. She turned her face toward it the way she might toward warmth.

Adora gripped the railing and looked out at the living world she had helped free. The chipped tiles beneath her feet held the last trace of the heat from the day. Moonlight gathered in their broken seams. Repairs were visible in thin lines crossing stone that had once seemed whole. Adora felt a pressure behind her ribs like a tightness under stillness.

The edge of the rail pressed into her palms, cold and firm. A chipped place bit lightly beneath her thumb. She focused on that, on the grit of the stone, on something real enough to understand.

The war had been terrible, but it had made goodness clear. There had been people to protect, a Horde to fight, Prime to stop. She'd known exactly how to stand on the right side of the line.

Now, Catra was asleep behind her. Bow and Glimmer were probably laughing somewhere down the hall. Bright Moon was full of open windows and repaired walls and creatures returning to cracks in the stone. No one was asking her to defend it. No one was telling her what counted as right anymore.

Adora tried to make the feeling smaller. She was just tired. It had been a long day, even if nothing had happened, a day with too much room in it. Anyone would feel unsettled after so much change, anyone would need time.

Her hands on the rail looked slightly unfamiliar, the knuckles too white, the grip too tense. She looked out at all that living brightness and felt the question rise, quiet and merciless.

How was she supposed to know where to stand now?

Chapter 2: Hesitation

Chapter Summary

> When an unsettled creature appears in Bright Moon's gardens, Adora finds it harder than expected to do no harm.

Morning returned with the same softness and the same refusal to explain itself. Adora hadn't slept very well. She remembered the rail beneath her hands more clearly than any dream, the chipped place beneath her thumb, the question that had stayed with her after the moonlight faded.

By the time Adora reached the lower gardens, half of Bright Moon seemed to have gathered at the edge of the new growth. They stood where the path gave way to grass and flowering scaffolds and the pale gold tangle of vines that had climbed a little further overnight, always inching now across the garden walls. Guards, villagers, and a cluster of children pressed shoulder to shoulder behind a low bench. All of them were caught in that strange, collective stillness that happened when wonder and fear had become too braided to separate.

Adora's hands had curled into fists at her sides, She-Ra close to the surface, but Adora needed a plan first. Her eyes scanned the faces around her. Most were staring at the wall, but a couple looked to her, waiting. No one said She-Ra. They didn't need to. The name was already there in the way they made room for her, in the small backward steps, in the lifted faces turning relief into expectation before she had fully earned it.

The scent of the lower gardens clung to the back of her throat, sweet and damp. Around the central beds, vines lifted their new leaves toward the morning light, green and glossy and almost translucent at the edges. One near the fountain curled toward the sun, then stopped, trembling faintly as if listening.

Then something stirred along the wall by the shadowed archway. What had first appeared to be part of the stone moved in a way that revealed a creature. Spiked ridges rose along its back like jagged pieces of the wall had grown a spine and decided to breathe. Its scales were stone gray, dull and rough until it shifted, and then blue shimmer slid beneath them, the way light moved under ice.

Adora's breath caught. For one suspended moment, the whole garden seemed to pause with it. Then one large foot lifted above the grass and stayed there, delicate and uncertain, as if the creature had forgotten whether the ground could be trusted. Its ear frills stood rigid on either side of its head, wide and trembling, lined with fine filaments that caught the light. They made it look larger. They made it look terrified.

The reptilian creature lowered its raised foot. Then lifted another. Its body rocked forward, halted, rocked back. It lumbered with too many feet to choose a direction. Adora made out at least six legs. It turned its head toward the gathered people and froze.

Its frills flared wider. It shuffled sideways, awkward and sudden, trying to get behind a curtain of flowering vines. The vines stirred a bit before it reached them. The motion sent the creature jolting away from them. It bumped against the low stone border of a bed and stopped again.

Children whispered excitedly from behind the bench. "It's huge. It's amazing."

Adora lifted a hand without thinking, raising it between the creature and the crowd. It was a gesture for calm, a gesture that assumed her body knew what calm was supposed to look like.

Footsteps came fast behind her.

"Adora," Catra called.

She'd slipped through the edge of the crowd with her ears angled forward and her tail low. Her eyes went from Adora's face, to

Adora’s hand, to the creature in the shade. For half a second, Catra’s fingers brushed her shoulder. It was quick enough that no one else would have noticed. A small contact, warm and precise.

“Big wall lizard,” Catra said under her breath. “Great. Love that for us.”

Adora almost laughed. It came out as a thin exhale instead.

“You thinking or panicking?” Catra asked quietly.

Adora stared at the creature. It stared back with a dark, round eye. “I’m trying to tell the difference,” she said.

“Please tell me no one poked it,” Glimmer said from beside her.

“No one poked it,” one of the gardeners answered immediately.

Bow crouched near the edge of the path with his tracker pad, scanning it. Then the scan chimed once.

The creature jerked.

“Sorry,” Bow whispered to it, then winced at his own tracker. “Sorry. Sorry. I’m turning that off.”

“Bow,” Adora said softly. “Can you tell if it’s hurt?”

Bow shook his head.

Adora stepped forward and noticed everyone watching. Her lifted hand felt suddenly strange in the air, too visible and empty. She’d saved Etheria and now it was alive all around her and she didn’t know where to touch it.

Swift Wind’s voice rang out, “Adora, it’s not angry. It’s scared out of its mind."

She opened her mouth. Nothing came.

The creature’s feathery frills shuddered. Its head tipped toward the bench, then toward the scaffold, then back to the shadows. Its chest moved fast. One back foot scraped against stone.

Catra's hand closed around her arm. “Adora." Low and certain. "It's about to bolt."

She'd seen it too, the same moment Catra named it. The creature's weight had shifted back onto its haunches, frills pulled tight against its neck, one foreleg lifting. She opened her mouth to call the crowd back.

It lunged sideways, faster than anything that large should have moved, six legs striking the grass in a frantic scramble.

One of the children who had crept forward from behind the bench went down hard against the stone border of the nearest bed.

The creature recoiled, then stumbled back toward the vines and shadows.

The child sat up immediately, already looking at his own arm with more interest than distress, a bright thin line of red catching the light.

The cut was small. The fear around it was not. Adora reached inward before she could think better of it and called out, “For the honor of Grayskull.”

She felt it move through her hands first. Light gathered in her palms, ran up through her fingers, and her hands became larger. They were luminous and capable of so much. The rest followed. She-Ra stood where Adora had been. The sword formed in her grip and power coursed through her.

The creature stopped moving. Not the slow settling of something calmed. It stopped mid-motion, one leg still lifted, frills held rigid. One second it had been lumbering. The next it was fully still, like it was overridden. It barely even seemed to breathe. A thin line of

saliva threaded from the corner of its jaw, silver in the light. It didn't twitch to break it.

"It trusts you," a villager said, voice warm with relief.

Her hands were still glowing. Or it stopped choosing, she thought.

One of the guards had lowered her staff, but her hand stayed on the shaft, knuckles white. She was watching the creature's eye.

Its dark eye fixed on She-Ra with a glassy stillness that made the back of her neck prickle. It stared through her, fixed on nothing, not even blinking. She couldn't tell, looking into it, whether what she was seeing was calm or just absence. She didn't know if those were different things.

She glanced at Swift Wind. His ears had flattened against his head.

She crossed quickly to the child and crouched down. The glow in her hands softened when she pressed them gently to the cut, warmth moving through her palms and into the skin, the light finding the damage the way it always did. The child watched with his mouth open. The cut closed cleanly.

From somewhere in the crowd she heard, “Good thing She-Ra was here."

The child looked up at her. "How do you always know what to do?"

She-Ra's hands were still faintly glowing. Adora looked at them for a moment before she looked at the child. The question was genuine but it had landed wrong. The certainty in it described someone Adora wasn't sure she recognized. She didn’t always know. She had just been fast enough, or slow enough, or present enough, that the mistakes hadn't outweighed the help yet.

Still, she answered kindly. “I try to listen and help where I can. When I get it wrong, I try to fix it."

The child considered this. Then he looked at his hand again. “You fixed this.”

“Yes,” she said softly. “I fixed that.”

She-Ra looked down at her own radiant hands. For the first time that day, she wished they were smaller.

Swift Wind moved to stand beside her as the crowd began to ease. He stood with his shoulder close to her arm and looked out at the creature, which still had not moved, and after a moment he said, quietly, “It'll find its way when the crowd clears."

The others dispersed. When Adora let the transformation fade, the creature's chest hitched before finding its rhythm again. The suspended leg came down hard, uncontrolled, and it stumbled sideways as if waking from a fall. Then it turned from the vines and lumbered back through a gap in the stone wall toward the woods, six feet finding the ground one after another.

Bow lowered his tracker pad without making another note. That, somehow, was worse than if he had asked a dozen questions. It was like he had seen something he didn't know how to record.

Glimmer looked at the path the creature had taken, then at Adora. “We’ll keep people back from this part of the garden for now,” she said. Just the next thing that could be done.

…

Her room was quiet when they got back. It felt almost altered, though nothing had changed. The waterfall kept softly rushing. Catra sat beside her on the edge of the bed. "You were trying not to scare it. That matters.”

Adora stayed silent for a long moment. She heard what Catra meant. She also heard the child hitting the stone. She’d waited too long to act.

“Adora,” Catra pressed softly.

“I know,” Adora finally replied, but she meant something different than Catra.

Catra's hand found hers. Adora let it stay there.

Her own hands looked unfamiliar again. They seemed capable of more than felt reasonable. They could heal. They could harm. They could make the wrong thing happen by waiting, or by moving too soon. Everyone kept mistaking the result for certainty.

She thought of the tiny blue lizard from the day before, vanishing into the cracked wall with its feathered ears and shimmering back. It had seemed harmless then. Strange, yes, but small enough to leave alone and just let live.

Today, something larger with the same shimmer had stood frightened beneath too many watching eyes, and leaving it alone had hurt someone. Acting had done something worse, or something better, or maybe both. She still couldn't tell. Maybe there was no connection. Maybe that was the part she couldn't make fit.

Adora closed her fingers carefully around Catra’s. She wanted the gesture to mean she understood. It only meant she was trying.

She had stood between the creature and the crowd. She had stood where everyone needed her. Her hand still remembered the child’s healed skin. Her eyes still remembered the creature going still. None of it told her whether she had been good.

Chapter 3: Roots

Chapter Summary

> When a village asks for She-Ra’s help with overgrowth, Adora expects a simple repair. The roots go deeper than she thought.

Adora sat alone in her familiar tall chair in the War Room of Bright Moon, the cup of cold tea beside her forgotten, her fingers tracing the inked surface of Bow's meticulously labeled map. The room had no windows but still felt luminous, lit with a large crystal fixture that glinted off the gold-trimmed molding and reflected from the polished floor. All around her murals stretched up to the vaulted ceiling showing the past heroes of Etheria, their faces turned upward as if toward some distant, guiding light.

She read through the map’s notations dotted with exclamation marks and overzealous arrows. Her jaw tightened as she scanned for what was wrong, what could be fixed, and what she could do first. The murals seemed to watch her, the faces all certain in a way she never quite felt.

This, though, she understood: a broken road blocking off a well. Moorlet, one of the smallest villages on the edge of the Whispering Woods, had requested She-Ra’s help. Overgrowth damage needed to be addressed, broken roads and walls fixed. This was a simple enough situation, the kind she knew how to handle. It felt like the restoration work she had done in the first months after Horde Prime fell, when the work had been hard and simple and she had known every evening that she had done things right.

Adora made one more careful mark, rolled the map tight enough to crease the edges, and left. She had a plan. That was the same as being ready, wasn't it?

…

Adora crested the ridge near midday and took in the village below. The growth from the Whispering Woods had not merely encroached, but fully bloomed. Flowers and vines spilled over cottage roofs in cascades of violet, pink, gold and green.

As she walked the descending path the aliveness intensified. Ferns unfurled and then curled tight as she passed, with an almost eager motion. A patch of toadstools near her boot released spores in a synchronized puff, the cloud drifting upward in a deliberate spiral. A hedgerow of silver-leaved shrubs shivered though no wind blew.

The village itself emerged from the green riot in pieces. The central well was blocked by a path split by brambles. A woman stood at the edge with two buckets, studying it with the resigned patience of someone who had already tried three other routes. A wall that had stood for centuries bowed outward, as ferns pressed through from within.

Bow's map had marked the central path as priority. In the War Room it had seemed straightforward, just a need to restore that road and the well access. Standing here, she could see things the map hadn't shown. The root system ran under the path rather than across it. The brambles had grown along the old clay drainage channel. A secondary path had been worn in around the worst of it, smooth with use.

Adora walked the full perimeter of the village before touching anything. The wall that bowed outward she left alone as the plants pressing through its base were old. The mortar had already reknit around them. The brambles splitting the central path were newer growth, opportunistic, and the fissure beneath them was still wide open. The vines on the cottage roofs she assessed one by one. Most were not doing damage and she resolved to leave them. One cottage at the edge of the village had growth so densely woven through its eastern wall that there was nearly more vine than stone. Still she walked past it twice before deciding.

“For the honor of Grayskull,” Adora said with quiet power. The light built from within her, as she lengthened and transformed. The armor formed around her like a second skin. Everything felt like a natural extension of herself but with a luster that belonged to myth.

She turned to the split path. She knelt and placed both hands along the stone at the gap’s edge. She reached through the land with her power and found the place where the magic had driven too hard. It was tight, like a living thing clenched around itself, forcing growth through every crack it could find. The brambles were only the part everyone could see. Underneath, the whole sub-terrain quivered like it had been wound taut.

Gold spread from her hands and through the broken path in slow threads. The brambles slackened. The soil settled enough to make the path passable again. Adora understood that making something stop hurting was not the same as making it fully whole. She kept her hand firm against the ground until the strain beneath it eased.

When she stood, the brambles had not vanished. They still crowded near the edges of the path, tangled and thorned and alive. Now they no longer blocked the way to the well.

She returned to the cottage at the end of the village. The growth there was more entangled than anywhere else. She pressed both hands into the base of it and felt the roots extending further than the surface growth had suggested.

She had thought, at first, that the growth was superficial, a vine against stone. Now her hands found the cavity where roots had twined below, and she felt the gap between what showed and what was. Her fingers followed a root down, down, through soil packed hard as…

…packed hard as the training course floor, the rubberized grit that shredded palms if she fell. She was eight. Smaller than the others. Her lungs burned as she pushed through a training course that

was not designed for a body of her size. Shadow Weaver's silhouette was in the observation window, dark against the green lights. She kept moving. She finished. She didn't remember finishing. She remembered waking in the med bay, being told she'd set a record, and feeling only relief that she hadn't had to see disappointment. She hadn't even asked what the record was.

Then, her hands were back in the roots once more. Soil was embedded in her nails. The cottage wall loomed above her. She made her decision.

The vine was not trying to break the wall. It was holding too hard. Etheria's magic had rushed into it until every crack looked like a place to grip, until every weakness in the wall became a place it had to fill.

She pressed her hands deeper into the soil around the roots. Her power moved through the system in golden strands, steadying the frantic force at its source. The vine trembled. Then it slackened, loosening by degrees from the stone and mortar where it had threaded itself through the cottage wall.

When she finished, she stepped back. The vine had released the wall. It no longer pushed through the cottage, but the places it had entered remained open.

From the central path a villager called out, "Thank you, She-Ra."

Adora watched as people reached the well again to bring water back to their homes. A relieved laugh filled the air. She felt the old certainty settling through her.

The light shifted like a daymoon had slipped behind a cloud. Then came the low groan of settling stone. Adora felt the vibration up through the soles of her boots. She knew before she turned.

The corner of the cottage sank, dropping barely a finger's width into the looser soil. The eastern wall bowed inward very slightly as the thick weave of vine and root that had been acting as mortar, as brace, as hidden architecture was no longer there to hold it.

Her stomach sank with it. A crack opened along the base of the wall, thin and definitive. The door to the cottage shifted in its frame. The owner tried it, and it didn’t close fully anymore.

A tightness coiled in her chest, then climbed to her throat. Her shoulders tensed and rose toward her ears. Her armor suddenly felt less like a second skin, her pauldrons heavy against her shoulders. For a second, sound narrowed. The villagers’ voices thinned behind the pulse in her ears.

"You couldn't have known," the woman said. She had set down her buckets, wandered over from the well. Her voice was gentle, almost puzzled by the distress she saw. "We asked you to clear it."

Adora nodded tightly. She stared at the wall where she had pressed her hands, at the gap between what she had intended and what had now occurred. Not knowing was really just failure by another name. She had done what had been asked, planned and prepared diligently, yet somehow it still hadn’t been enough.

The cottage sat lower now, vulnerable in a way it hadn't been before she'd touched it. The vine and the stone had become a single thing, and she had decided they shouldn't be. She had reached into the soil with mythic power and separated them, and now the wall was stressed in new places.

She looked at the crack in the wall. It was thin enough to cover with a thumb. It wasn't large enough to matter. It was exactly large enough to stay.

A villager produced a length of timber from a nearby shed. Another helped wedge it beneath the sagging corner with the easy coordination of people who had been accommodating the imperfections of old buildings for generations. The woman with the buckets produced rope from her apron and lashed the brace to the doorframe.

"Gives it character," one of the men said, grinning at the new angle of the wall. "Like old Marn's place before the storm took his roof."

"Your grandfather's cottage leaned worse than this for twenty years," the woman replied, and they laughed. The sound was warm and unburdened, the kind that came from knowing a thing could be mended.

She-Ra stood at the edge of it, suddenly aware of how the light caught the gold of her pauldrons, how the green of the growth seemed to dim against the brightness she carried. She had come to restore the road, clear the wall, separate the wild from the built. But the villagers moved around the lean as if it belonged to them already. The brace would hold. The crack would stay. They would build around it.

She let her transformation go quietly, the armor receded, like a tide pulling back from shore, leaving her smaller, just Adora in the afternoon light. She watched the villagers work, unable to meet their eyes. She said something like thank you, or I'm sorry, or both. She wasn't even sure the words had come out in the right order.

She began walking back up the path toward the ridge. The village sounds faded behind her. The ferns unfurled as she passed, then curled tight behind her. The toadstools released no spores this time. The hedgerow shivered once, silver leaves whispering against each other, and fell still. The woods smelled of wet soil and the too-strong sweetness of flowers that seemed to follow her everywhere on Etheria nowadays.

She reached the crest and stopped. Below, Moorlet had already returned to itself. She could see the temporary brace from here, visible only as a dark line against the stone, and the crack she couldn't see from this distance but knew was there. The village moved on. Smoke drifted from a chimney. A child crossed the central path with a bucket, using the route she'd cleared.

The Whispering Woods were alive around her and entirely indifferent to what she had done or meant to do or understood too late. The vines would keep spilling over roofs. The roots would keep finding cracks. The growth would not ask permission, and it would not apologize for what it held together. She stood on the ridge for a moment longer than she needed to. Then she turned and walked back toward Bright Moon.

…

Catra was on the bed when she got back, propped against the pillows with a book open across her knees. She had the focused, slightly territorial quality she got when she'd found a comfortable position and intended to keep it. She looked up when Adora entered, ears swiveling forward with the automatic alertness that couldn't be fully tamed, even now.

Adora sat down on the edge of the bed and started talking. The War Room, the map, Bow's excessive arrows. The walk down into Moorlet and the way the growth had looked from the ridge. The assessment she'd done before touching anything. The drainage channel she'd noticed that the map had missed. How she'd left the roof vines alone.

"Look at you, checking things. Leaving vines alone. Next you'll be napping in meadows and writing poetry about clouds," Catra teased playfully bumping their shoulders.

Adora described just how she'd closed the gap in the main well path by moving the brambles. Then Adora reached the cottage, and her throat closed around the next part. The silence went on for a moment. She saw again the brace beneath the cottage corner, the crack thin enough to cover with a thumb and exactly large enough to stay.

"There was a lot of growth. More than Bow's map showed. The root systems were... complicated." The memory flash, the sinking structure, the villagers' absolution. She didn't know how to explain any of that. "It went fine," she said.

Catra's ears flattened slightly. She looked at Adora over the top of her book. Held the look for a moment, steady and without pressure. Her tail gave one tight flick. The unspoken stretched between them. “Okay," Catra said, softer than the word usually came from her.

Then she looked back down at her book, thumb finding her place as she resumed reading. The pages turned with a rustled whisper. The waterfall rushed softly. The silence was not empty; it was full of everything Adora had left at the village edge, everything she had carried up the ridge and through the Woods and still could not bring herself to set down.

Adora looked at her hands, the soil still embedded beneath her nails. She could still feel the texture of it, the packed soil and the root system going down further than she'd expected. Roots that had twined through gaps she hadn't known were load-bearing, the moment when vine and stone became two things instead of one and the wall groaned its protest.

She hadn't told Catra about the crack in the wall. She hadn't told her about the door that no longer closed, or the sound the foundation made as it sank, or the way the villagers had laughed while they built the brace without her. She didn’t say that she had reached into the soil with mythic power and something she couldn't see broke.

She thought of the med bay ceiling, white and close. Being told she'd set a record. The relief that had come not from doing what was worth doing but from not having to see disappointment. Then she had not even asked what the record was. Now she could not tell Catra what exactly had happened.

Catra's eyes moved across the page, tracking words Adora couldn't see, and in that unspoken gap, Adora felt the distance between them measured in the width of a thumb.



Chapter 4: Vigilance

Chapter Summary

> When crystalline vines rise over Bright Moon, Adora acts. This time, the danger may not be what’s growing.

The early light had already begun brightening the walls when Adora realized she was doing it again, cataloging cracks in the stones and spreading vines before she even noticed the colors of the morning moonrise. She stood by the window in her sleep clothes, one hand curled tight around the curtain. She had been awake long enough to know the feeling wouldn't just pass. The rush of the waterfall seemed louder than yesterday, though she had no way to measure it.

From this high up, everything looked ordered. The hedges below divided the grounds into clean curves. Vines climbed the eastern walls along their trellises with obedient precision. Beyond them, the forest softened into the blue-green distance. The gardens looked effortless from a distance. Up close, every bloom depended on careful pruning. Every path through the gardens existed because someone had decided where wandering should end.

The winged creatures had returned to the eastern parapet. That was supposed to be a good sign, she knew. She watched them settle and thought about migration paths, about what it meant that creatures were returning to routes no one fully understood, about all the things moving through Etheria right now that no one had mapped.

“If you’re planning to interrogate dawn, at least let me sleep through the boring parts.”

Adora startled slightly and let the curtain fall back into place. She had pulled it aside without realizing, spilling light across the bed. “Sorry. I didn’t mean to wake you.” She continued to stare out.

Catra approached and her arms came around her from behind, loose and easy. "Come back to bed."

Adora's gaze found the gap in the guard rotation below, the empty stretch of wall where a sentry should have been. "I'm not tired."

"Didn't say you were tired, said come back to bed." Catra pressed her face briefly into the side of Adora's neck. Her tail curled once around Adora's ankle and held. “What are you looking at anyway?”

“I’m just thinking.” She knew she should say more, but she wasn't even sure herself what was wrong. Really, everything was fine. There was no war. Etheria’s magic was more alive now. Adora was handling it. She had repaired the well path and fixed the hurt child. Why did she feel like she had done it wrong? The too-still creature in the garden and the sinking cottage corner both flashed through her mind and she felt that rising unease. How could she explain any of it when she barely understood herself?

Catra reached up to brush the hair from her shoulder, and Adora stayed a little too tense.

“Adora.”

“Nothing has really happened. Etheria is more alive now and I’m helping where I can with it. Everything has been handled. It's fine. I’m fine.” Adora looked over then.

Catra tucked her claw into her palm. Her tail flicked, then stilled deliberately. Her ears lowered a bit. “Okay.”

Adora carefully watched her expression, her body language, her tone, cataloging them like the gardens. She hated how carefully Catra had said it. Adora almost wished she’d push more. Then she could have been defending herself instead of just disappointing her.

Sudden movement flickered at the edge of the grounds. Shimmering vines along one of the distant garden walls lifted all at once. They rose together as though drawn by an unseen force, reaching toward a sky that had only just begun to lighten.

“Catra.”

“That’s new.”

Adora felt her unease resolve into something cleaner, a problem to solve.

…

They arrived at the garden wall to find the vines had grown dense, beautiful and wrong. Where once they had been pale gold and green, glossy and translucent at the edges, they were now fully crystalline. The stems wove upward in prismatic layers, catching the dawn light and splitting it into rainbows. The leading vines continued to reach up, spiraling slow and deliberate. They were forming something, almost weaving into a barrier. She couldn't quite tell exactly what, only that it was happening too quickly, and that the gardeners and guards gathering at the edges looked small and uncertain, watching it form. Bright Moon's banners shifted with each change in the wind as though testing for danger.

Adora felt the pull in her chest, do something now, don't hesitate this time. She didn't think further. She transformed. “For the honor of Grayskull.”

Light flooded her limbs, familiar and almost too freely. It felt faster than ever before. She-Ra stood where Adora had been, and her hands were already rising, already reaching toward the vines with power building in her palms before she had decided what to do with it. Her eyes lit white. Gold streamed from her palms.

The magic vines responded to her urgency. The spiraling, weaving tangle of plants shattered instantly, the whole structure of them coming apart at once into a cascade of luminous particles.

Harmless glittering specks hung in the air for a moment, beautiful and odd, before drifting down to coat the soil and the stone and the upturned faces. The gardeners and guards made a sound like collective awe.

Adora stood breathing hard in the sudden quiet, her hands still raised, her eyes still blazing. She felt her own power moving faster than thought, her body acting before she'd decided, and something in her chest twisted sideways into an older darkness.

The Fright Zone. She was small, the world a series of passageways where danger lived in the spaces between seconds. The rhythmic sound of boots filled the halls. The light went suddenly wrong and Shadow Weaver appeared with the shadows themselves creeping forward at her sides, electricity building on the air, crackling red energy emerging from her fingertips without warning.

It was never predictable. That was the worst part. One moment, Shadow Weaver spoke with her voice low and almost warm, her thumb resting against the shoulder seam of Adora's uniform in the rare gesture of approval that Adora would lean into. A moment when she was told she showed promise and the words landed in her chest like something she could build on.

She had learned to read the shift in Shadow Weaver's stance, the particular static feel of the silence before danger, the way a room's temperature changed when someone was about to be punished. She had to always watch, to try and anticipate anger. If she was fast enough and good enough and correct enough, she could sometimes keep the air from crackling. Sometimes had felt like enough to build around.

Then the glitter settled on her arms, her shoulders, her still-glowing hands. She felt Catra's eyes on her from somewhere behind, but she couldn't turn around yet. She was still waiting for the punishment that didn't come, still braced for the voice that would tell her she had done it wrong. The vines and barrier were gone. Everything was handled. She had not chosen to shatter

them. She had only chosen to act, and the acting had done the rest.

She lowered her hands slowly, and the light in her eyes dimmed, and she stood in the silence of the garden waiting for someone to tell her what she had destroyed.

Catra stepped closer, but didn't touch her. “Adora.”

"Don't." The word came out sharp, and Adora heard it, the echo of temper in her own voice. She flinched from herself. "I just… don't look at me like that."

"Like what?" Catra had tensed fully, her claws out, then seemed to force herself to ease and retract.

"Like you can see something I can't,” Adora said softly.

Catra's ears flattened, then rose again, uncertain. "I’m not judging you. I’m trying to figure out whether you’re about to run, yell, or pretend none of this happened.” She stopped, her tail lashing once. "So tell me what you need.”

Adora didn't know. That was the problem. She needed the vines to not have been a threat. She needed to not have felt the relief of shattering them. She needed to not be standing here with gold still crackling in her fingertips and fear still coiled in her chest and no name for any of it. Truth felt unsafe, a hallway she didn't know how to walk, where the light might shift at any moment and leave her exposed.

Maybe she was becoming the danger that needed to be obeyed and feared. The one who moved too fast, who shattered before understanding, who spoke in sharp edges and expected compliance. Or maybe she was still the frightened child in the training room, still watching for the shift, still trying to control what she could to stay safe. Maybe she could no longer tell the difference.

"I need…" She stopped. Her hands were still trembling. She pressed them flat against her thighs and felt the last of the She-Ra light gutter out, leaving her ordinary and exhausted and no less dangerous for it. "I need to check the perimeter. Make sure nothing else is… make sure it's all handled."

"Adora, it's handled. You handled it. That's not…"

"Then I'll handle it again." She was already turning, already scanning the garden walls, the hedges, the distant forest line, looking for the next thing, the next unmapped movement, the next threat that might arrive before she was ready. She couldn't stop. Stopping meant feeling, and feeling meant not knowing what to do with any of it, and not knowing was the hall where the shadows crept in, where the temperature dropped, where anything could happen.

Catra said something else, low and careful, but Adora was already moving too far away to fully hear, already vigilant, already gone inside herself where it was safer, where the only thing she had to control was her own relentless forward motion. Catra took one step after her, then stopped.

Adora kept moving. Everything was fine. She would make it fine. She would keep making it fine, again and again, until the word meant something, until she believed it, until she didn't have to feel anything at all.

Chapter 5: Containment

Chapter Summary

> Etheria’s magic is surging again, and Adora is determined to get ahead of it before it causes any more harm.

Dawn had barely reached the eastern towers, and Adora was already up and moving, already trying to keep the day from outrunning her. She dressed quickly, her gaze darting around her room. Soft light collected now along the edges of the balcony. The waterfall looked controlled, though up close it fractured into countless separate drops, somehow falling together. The water followed the same course it always had. The vines crept ever further across the balcony, making new paths as they grew.

She glanced toward Catra, still asleep in their bed, and watched her for a long moment. Catra slept deeply, one hand curled near her face, claws retracted. They hadn’t seen much of each other after yesterday morning. Catra had already been asleep by the time Adora returned to their room the night before.

She kept thinking about yesterday’s sudden surge. Something was happening. Etheria’s magic seemed to be shifting. She still didn’t fully understand it. She couldn't be sure she was doing right if she didn't know what was happening, couldn't be certain she wasn't causing harm if she wasn't controlling the response. She needed to get ahead of it, to monitor it before it became something worse. She was She-Ra, Etheria’s protector. Waiting had never saved anyone.

Catra had been reluctant to wake early yesterday, and Adora had already disturbed her sleep enough. There was no reason to wake her now for a problem that Adora hadn’t even fully defined. She carefully pulled the blanket up an inch where it had slipped from Catra's shoulder. Then she left.

She opened the door softly and stepped out into the hall. Her footsteps echoed off the polished floors. There was comfort in waking before anyone else. Problems had more edges in the stillness. When the castle hadn’t yet filled with voices, the day seemed more manageable.

The War Room was empty at this hour, which was how she wanted it. Adora slid into her chair. She reached for the tracker pad and called Entrapta.

She appeared almost instantly, tucked under a console with a coil of wire wound around one arm and her hair holding three tools at once, obviously midway through dismantling or rebuilding something.

“Morning,” Adora said with an amused smile.

“Is it?” Entrapta ducked out from beneath the console enough to see the morning light. “Oh, yes. Good morning.”

“I need your help with something.”

Entrapta sat up more fully. “Is it dangerous, mysterious, or currently exploding?”

“Definitely mysterious, possibly dangerous.”

“Excellent.”

“Not excellent.”

“Right. Concerning.”

“I think the planet’s magic is having more fluctuations,” Adora explained. “Since the Heart, there’s been more growth and new animal migrations, but it seems like something more now.”

Entrapta’s eyes lit up with interest. “Oh, that's a good project. I've actually been collecting ambient readings since the week after the Heart released, so I have comparative data going back.” She

immediately moved to pull up data on her console and ran a new scan. After a brief pause she added, “There have been some recent surges. One in Moorlet, yesterday’s in Bright Moon, and a sharp uptick happening now in Alwyn.”

“In Alwyn, now?” Adora instantly straightened, her eyes wide and her grip tightening around the tracker pad. “Does it look dangerous?”

“It is definitely unusual. I don’t have a measurement here for danger-level. It does seem like it might be spreading.”

“Thanks, Entrapta,” Adora said, already mobilizing. “Let me know later what else you’re able to find out.”

"Of course! This is going to be such an interesting dataset.”

Adora disconnected the call, tucked the tracker pad back on its shelf and immediately headed out. She walked fast. As she approached Alwyn, she cataloged every change along the path.

Every small irregularity became worthy of notice. Hedgerows on the eastern side grown another handspan. Grasses taller and a shimmering blue-green since the Heart. Moss spreading with unusual density. Three places where the road's surface cracked with something green coming through. The road no longer had clear edges. Encroaching growth had narrowed it. Plants no longer content to remain beside the path.

A slight hum in the air and the strong scent of pollen reached her first. The fields began half a mile out from the village. Ordinarily she would have seen them before the village itself, the wide flat geometry of planted rows, the different crops making an organized patchwork across the lowland. Instead all she saw were flowers. They were enormous.

They had come up through the planted rows without any regard for what was already there. The blossoms rose high, the size of wagon wheels, each one opening into another until the field no

longer seemed composed of individual plants at all. It was both stunning and shocking at once.

The colors of the petals seemed impossibly saturated, violet so deep it seemed to drink light, yellow so bright it gathered the morning glow into itself, and pink that seemed to have swallowed the ripest moonberry. They were extraordinary. They were also everywhere.

As she approached she could see that between and beneath and around them, the food crops were struggling. The grain rows in the shadow of the largest flowers were bent. Root vegetables were being displaced. Seven rows were compromised.

Beauty had become impossible to separate from suffocation. The flowers had not grown wildly, not exactly. They had grown with purpose, each stem forcing upward, each root claiming space, each blossom opening too wide. Growers were working with the focused, quiet efficiency of people who had moved past distress into dealing with what was in front of them.

The field kept breaking into pieces she couldn’t hold together. The brightness of a petal. The sound of a grower's voice arriving a half-beat late. The yellowed grain. The count of compromised rows. Each thing demanded her full attention and she could not make them add up to a single clear action.

She counted seven rows, no nine. No, she’d counted the same row twice. Numbers gave her an edge to grasp but even they were slipping away. She could turn back. She could find Glimmer, or Bow, or even just sit down until the pieces reassembled. The thought arrived complete and then vanished, smothered by the next one. They needed her now.

Her fingers were suddenly tingling. She looked down at her hands. The faintest trace of gold moved under her skin, at the tips near her nails.

She had not summoned it.

Her chest had tightened without her noticing and suddenly she couldn’t draw a full breath. She noticed the sound of her own breathing, too loud in her ears. It arrived a half-second after she felt her chest expand.

Beyond the bloom, a farmer was tending the rows that remained. Adora forced air back into her lungs. They might lose food. She was standing here with a sword made of light at her bidding, overwhelmed by a feeling she could not even explain. They needed her steady. There’d be time to understand what had happened to her after the fields were safe.

Nearby, growers were transferring seedlings and clearing narrow channels between the rows.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” Gold light flooded fully through her, reconstructed her, made her into something that did not tremble.

The growers stepped back. They always stepped back for She-Ra. Adora saw their retreat as proof she could not stop, proof that this was what was needed.

She knelt at the edge of the overbloom and pressed her hands into the soil, feeling the magic of Etheria. It felt tightly wound, as it had in Moorlet, magic driven past growth into compulsion. Golden light threaded from her hands to meet it and force it to ease. It yielded.

The overbloom reacted at once, a recoil that shuddered through the fields. Flowers snapped closed and pulled quickly back. The soil beneath her feet felt unnaturally still. The magical hum on the air had not fully disappeared, just lowered to a tight, trapped pitch.

Had she pushed too hard? She’d kept it from becoming anyone else's problem. That was what mattered.

When the last enormous blossom had folded shut, she stood in the field as She-Ra. The grain remained flattened in pale rows, each stalk bent inside the indentations the flowers had left

behind. Someone quickly knelt beside it without looking up at her, trying to determine what could be salvaged.

None of the farmers and growers approached her. They might have been simply focused on the crops, or they might have been afraid to come closer. She could not tell.

“Will they open again?” someone asked from behind her.

She didn't answer. She didn't really have an answer and they weren't even asking her. Still, the silence felt like one more thing she had left behind. She turned and walked back toward Bright Moon, the gold fading from her skin only when she was out of sight.

As Adora approached the castle, she stopped and asked the guards for increased watches and expanded patrols, her authority unquestioned. No one paused to ask whether Glimmer had authorized them. Every change in the landscape, every shift in growth pattern, every unusual color or height or behavior was to be reported directly to her. No detail too small. She would tell Glimmer after she had a fuller picture.

She patrolled the edges of the Whispering Woods herself, making sure nothing else was surging toward the castle before she was even aware. The daymoons began to dip below the horizon, the sky deepening into nightfall.

She entered the empty War Room. The kingdom felt measurable here. Rivers were lines. Forests were color. Nothing could grow while she looked away.

The tracker pad buzzed, and Entrapta’s face appeared flushed with discovery, her hair moving in excited patterns. “Adora! The anomalies are not fully random! I thought they might be initially, but there's a pattern. Not predictable in a simple sense. The intervals aren't regular and the locations aren't evenly distributed, but there's a structure to the variance.”

“What type of structure?” Adora asked.

“I don’t know yet! That’s the exciting part!”

“Can you build something that alerts us when readings change?”

“I can build something that alerts us when readings change from whatever we decide normal is.”

Adora glanced at her. “Isn’t that the same thing?”

Entrapta’s hair paused above the controls. “Not necessarily.”

Adora's hand tightened on the edge of a map. She felt a flicker of understanding, but she pushed forward, compelled to find the pattern before anything else could go wrong. Entrapta talked about probability matrices and constructing a predictive model from the emerging pattern. Adora listened carefully, sending every update from the patrols as soon as it arrived.

At some point, the tracker flashed with Catra’s name. Adora’s thumb hovered. For one second, the room seemed too quiet. Then she silenced it. She would answer when she understood enough to explain, when she could explain without making Catra look at her like that again.

The maps lay open beneath her hands. Rivers became lines. Forests became blocks of color. Here, everything had edges. Here, even the forests stopped where the ink told them to. Etheria looked almost obedient from above.

Entrapta’s data filled the screen point by point. With enough reports, enough watches, enough measurements, perhaps nothing would be able to change without warning her first. The map’s edge dug into her palm. Adora could not prevent what she did not see, so she would see all of it.

Chapter 6: Evidence

Chapter Summary

> The Woods are changing, and the reports are not enough. Outside the War Room, Catra tries to reach Adora before she retreats further.

Soft light drifted down through the branches of the Whispering Woods, dappling the ground below. The dark-barked trees were entwined with bright green spreading vines, their roots crowded by bursts of colorful flowers and fresh curling shoots. Birdsong carried gently on the morning breeze.

Adora's shoulders tensed. She told herself it was just readiness, only alertness. Her body was simply making sure she stayed aware of each change around her. She kept walking forward on the path through the trees.

A deer stood motionless beside a large fern, its three star-shaped pupils gazing past her, almost through her. It didn't startle at her presence, didn't even flick an ear. Adora's fingers twitched as if to summon her sword before she made herself move on.

The riverbed came into view. Its bank had softened from yesterday, eroded further inward. The stones lay pale now where the water had retreated.

A marker post stood at the fork ahead, half-buried in vines that had not been there yesterday. Adora crouched and pulled at them. The stems clung wetly to the wood, bright sap smearing across the post.

Yesterday she had carved a notch into the wood to mark the patrol route. The cut was gone now, sealed under new bark. Her breathing shortened. Trees healed. That was good. Healing was good. Unless the forest was healing over the things she needed to see.

She turned toward the ridge. Cracks spread through the packed soil angling toward the imprints her boots had left there the day before. The ground had cracked cleanly, as though something beneath it had been holding too firmly for too long and had now quietly let go.

Adora knelt and measured the cracks. She marked one, looked away, looked back, then doubted the measurement and checked again. New vines curled around her bootprint.

Her chest tightened. She'd been here just yesterday and it had been all clear and stable. Now, between her patrols, when she wasn't watching, Etheria's magic had acted again.

Had the night patrol noted this? She wasn't sure if this ridge was on their rotation, but maybe someone had seen. Perhaps this had been detailed in a report she had not yet read.

She found herself already on the path back to the castle before she'd really even made the decision to turn around. The walk back blurred. Her boots carried her toward the building mechanically. The rush of the waterfall seemed muffled. She needed to know right away what else might have been logged.

In the castle's near garden, banners hung between the golden lamp posts in hues of renewal rather than victory. Castle aides moved past with armfuls of ribbon, their voices low and bright. Adora slowed, blinking as if surfacing from deep water.

The Seasonal Blooming ceremony was planned for the next day. The first one since the end of the war. Two gardeners stood near the doorway, draping a garland of fresh blossoms over the arch. One laughed, bright and unguarded. Adora's chest pinched at the sound. They were planning for tomorrow as if tomorrow were a thing that could be trusted. The sweet scent of the flowers should have loosened her chest. Instead, she just walked through.

She passed by a stretch of tall arched windows and caught her own reflection in the glare against the distant green-blue of the

Woods fading toward the horizon. She saw the dark smudges beneath her eyes. She looked away quickly.

Around the next corner she heard low voices. She couldn’t make out words. Still, she noted Glimmer’s measured cadence, Bow’s gentler interjections, and Catra’s sharper tone weaving together.

Adora stepped into view. They stopped, all three of them mid-gesture and word. The silence fell so completely that Adora heard the soft call of a winged creature from outside the castle.

Glimmer's hand was still half-raised from making a point. Bow's mouth had barely closed. Catra's eyes found hers immediately and Adora saw her throat work once, swallowing whatever she'd been about to say.

Heat rose in her face. They had been talking about her, worrying about her. Alwyn’s fields were still damaged, the Woods were shifting by the hour, and somehow she had become the thing they were trying to manage.

Adora forced a smile. “Hi, everything’s fine. Just checking in on reports.” She gestured toward the War Room.

She saw Catra's jaw tighten. Saw Glimmer and Bow exchange a glance.

"Okay, we’ll catch up later," Glimmer said, touching Bow's elbow. They moved past Adora with the soft urgency of people who knew when to become part of the scenery. Their footsteps faded down the corridor until the only sound left was Catra's breathing and the low calls of the creatures from outside.

Catra didn't move. She stood with her arms loose at her sides, and watched Adora with a stillness that was worse than shouting.

“What are you doing?” Catra asked.

Adora had already turned toward the War Room. “I just got back from patrol. I need to review the guard logs right away. Alwyn’s

yields are down ten percent and the magic in the Woods is getting worse.”

“I don’t care about the Woods right now.”

That made Adora look at her.

Catra’s ears were flat. Her tail lashed once, then went still. “I care that you’ve barely slept. I care that you keep disappearing before anyone can ask if you’re okay.”

“I’m not disappearing.”

“You left at dawn.”

“It was patrol.”

“You went alone. You didn’t even wake me.”

Adora’s hand tightened, curling into a fist.

Catra took a step closer. "You told me you needed to handle things. Fine. I let you handle things.” Her voice sharpened, “But this isn’t handling things, Adora. You're just... running the same patrol over and over and coming back farther away."

Adora saw the flash in Catra’s eyes, the old urge to snap, to make the room as loud as the feeling. Catra swallowed it down. Her jaw set hard. For a moment, her claws bit into her own palms before she carefully retracted them.

Adora angled her shoulders, bracing without thought.

“Stop doing that,” Catra said.

“Doing what?”

“Deciding what I can handle.”

Adora’s face went still. She heard the winged creatures’ calls fade. She noticed Catra's breathing change rhythm. She was too aware

of her own heartbeat in her throat.

Catra stepped even closer, her fingers resting against Adora's sleeve. Her voice dropped, rougher now. "You're looking at every glowing flower like it's proof of something. Like one field goes bad and that means you failed. Like the Woods move wrong and it means you're wrong."

Adora's arm twitched beneath Catra's touch. "That's not what I'm doing."

"Yes, it is." Catra's anger cracked, and fear showed through underneath it. Her mouth opened then closed. Her hands dropped to her sides and her claws flexed. "You're trying to make the whole planet into a list you can fix."

Adora stared at her, hollow-eyed with exhaustion.

Catra's expression shifted more raw. "You don't have to carry all of it," she said. "Not anymore. Not by yourself."

There was a plea in it, yet Adora only heard, you can't be trusted with this. "If I don't carry it," Adora said, her voice far too even, "who will?" Her hand opened then clenched again at her side.

Catra froze. Her tail rose then stilled and her shoulders hunched in. "Adora."

For one impossible second, Adora wanted to say, I don't know how to stop. The words were on the edge of her tongue, breath almost becoming sound. Catra would understand. Catra, who had clawed her way back from the end of everything, would understand too much.

And then Adora saw the dark circles beneath Catra's eyes too, the careful way she held herself, like she was braced for Adora to vanish mid-sentence. Her ears, usually so sharp with attention, now slightly back. No. Catra had already carried enough.

The crystal lights along the corridor seemed too bright, their glow sharpening against the walls. Adora looked down at her own hands and every line, every pore seemed to sharpen for a moment. Then the feeling passed, mostly.

“I need to check the Alwyn reports,” Adora said.

“No. You need to sleep.”

“I’ve rested enough. If the yields keep dropping, people will go hungry.”

Catra’s face twisted. Her tail drooped for a second before she steadied it.

Adora stepped quickly toward the War Room. Her boot scraped too loudly along the polished floor. The map waited where she had left it, covered in pins and notes and measurements that did not accuse her of anything.

Catra stayed where she was.

Adora noticed how the corridor behind her remained quiet. No footsteps followed. She imagined Catra standing still, tail motionless, deciding not to chase.

Adora did not look back. She told herself that it was good. It meant everyone understood there was important work to be done.

Her hand wrapped around the cool metal of the golden moon door handle. The War Room door felt heavy as she forced it open with a sharp pull. She heard claws on stone retreat, pause, come closer again, then stop. Adora let the door shut fully behind her.

Her back pressed against the door and she listened to the silence on the other side just for a moment. There was no knock. She straightened and reached for the tracker pad.

She reviewed the Woods night patrol report from the guards. Western wall, south bridge, eastern ridge all noted as clear with no unusual activity. Adora read it three times.

She could still see the cracks and the shift of the riverbank. The Woods had changed while everyone slept. Maybe the change had happened after the patrol? Or maybe she had missed things yesterday. That thought stayed.

She had set up increased watches and expanded patrols. She had asked for every change to be reported. Still, the map had been wrong before she reached it.

She added a red pin to the ridge. Then another at the riverbed. Then, after a moment, one at the place where the deer had stood gazing through her. The laughter of aides preparing the castle for the Seasonal Blooming ceremony carried through the door. Adora focused on the map. Three pins were not panic. They were just evidence.

Chapter 7: Threshold

Chapter Summary

> The Seasonal Blooming ceremony is meant to mark Etheria's renewal. Adora tries to stand with her friends and believe in it.

The flowered archway marked the official entrance to the courtyard. Bright vines wound around the white stone, opening into bursts of colorful blossoms. Children kept darting beneath it before the ceremony had even begun, laughing every time petals drifted down over their hair.

The near gardens had been further transformed overnight. Pastel ribbons in every shade wound around the potted shrubs that lined the procession path, connecting them in bands of color. Everywhere Adora looked, Etheria seemed determined to prove itself healed.

Still, Adora counted the exits and checked that vine growth wasn't encroaching further. Her shoulders were tight, her stance steady, and her eyes scanning constantly. She moved some nearby flower stands to get a better view. Was that a tiny crack in the arch?

"Adora, I need you to leave those alone," Glimmer said, practically vibrating with that particular energy she got when she'd been organizing something for weeks and it was finally happening.

Adora froze, her hand stilling on the flower stand.

Glimmer immediately winced. "I mean… not like you did something wrong. Just the decorators are still working there, and if the flower stands move, they're going to revolt."

Bow coughed into his hand. "They did mention revolt."

"A peaceful decorative revolt," Glimmer added quickly.

Bow handed Adora a folded map.

Adora opened it. The procession route had been marked in blue. The speech order was listed. The platform positions were labeled. The ceremonial bloom sites were notated. There were no patrol routes. No guard notes.

“This isn’t the full map.”

“The guard copy has the patrol notes. Yours has the procession.”

“Why?”

His smile softened. “Because you’re in the procession.”

Glimmer clasped her hands behind her back, standing suddenly straighter. “For the opening, I’d like you on the platform. It's the Blooming. The first one since everything. I want you up there with us.”

Adora blinked. “On the platform?”

“Yes.”

Adora looked toward it. “That’s not the best vantage point.”

Glimmer’s smile faltered. “It’s not supposed to be a vantage point.”

Bow’s voice went quieter. “You’re allowed to stand somewhere just because your friends want you there.”

So that was it. They wanted to keep an eye on her. She folded the map and slipped it into her pocket.

"Adora."

The voice came from behind her, low and familiar, making her chest loosen and clench at the same time. Catra appeared without announcement, arriving in Adora's peripheral vision and then simply being there.

She quietly asked, “You sleep at all?”

“Not…”

She stopped. Across the courtyard, one of the vines twitched around the edge of the arch. Or maybe it was only the wind.

“Enough,” Adora said. She turned back toward the arch, toward the ceremony, her jaw set. “I got enough.”

Catra's eyes narrowed, but she shifted slightly closer anyway, and the space between them shortened, and for a moment Adora was aware of Catra's hand beside hers, not quite touching. Adora felt the near contact like static electricity.

"She-Ra?" A villager, bright-eyed, leaning slightly forward from the edge of the path. "Is it true the magic is stronger this year because of you?"

The space between Adora's hand and Catra's widened.

Adora turned toward the villager. "Etheria's magic belongs to everyone now," she said.

The processional music began. Adora stood frozen, Catra's almost-touch still ghosting against her knuckles, the vine still twitching in her peripheral vision. She forced herself to relax, to turn toward where musicians were tuning with strings and bells. Adora found her place between Glimmer and Bow and tried to stay present.

Adora looked at the gardens full of people who had come from across Etheria to mark this day. All the Princesses were gathered. Netossa was in quiet conversation with Spinnerella, their hands loosely joined. Mermista looked faintly bored in the way that meant she was actually paying close attention, with Seahawk beside her and visibly restraining himself from making a speech of his own. Perfuma was in her element and Frosta and Entrapta stood beside her. Swift Wind had been given a place nearby, his coat brushed, his posture noble. Micah stood beside Castaspella at the center of the platform.

Catra stood near the back of the crowd, leaning against one of the gold lamp posts with her arms folded loosely over her chest. Melog pressed against her leg, shifting color faintly in the morning light. She absently rested a hand on Melog's head. Catra wasn't pretending not to watch her. That was worse, somehow.

The speeches came in the way ceremony speeches always did, one after another, each one reaching for what felt most true about the day and finding it in different words. Glimmer gave the opening statement. An elder from near the Plumerian border spoke about children who had grown up not knowing peacetime and were now learning what it looked like. Adora heard the words as if from underwater.

Castaspella stepped forward next, her circular headpiece catching the light, her voice carrying that particular resonance from often speaking ceremonial words. "Last year, Etheria was under attack. Now, because of She-Ra, Etheria lives. Because of She-Ra, magic returned to us."

People cheered with the specific fervor of those who had something to celebrate that they hadn't been sure they'd get. The sound rose up around her, warm and grateful and full of hope, and Adora smiled because She-Ra was supposed to smile when people said things like that.

On the faces all around her, the words were becoming warmth, relief, the celebration they were supposed to be. Glimmer had tears on her face and wasn't trying to hide them. Bow had given up all pretense of composure.

Adora looked out at the restored gardens, the flowers banked along the processional path, the ribbons wound deliberately through the shrubs, the faces turned upward the way the faces in the War Room murals turned upward, so certain.

Still the words made her uneasy. If magic returned because of her, then she was responsible for it. And if Etheria lived because of

She-Ra, then what did it mean when brambles split paths and flowers overwhelmed grain?

She did not have an answer. She just kept her smile exactly where it was.

Castaspella raised her hands and the sorcerers moved into position. They arranged themselves in a wide arc across the platform and the near garden, Micah to Castaspella's left, Glimmer to her right, the others filling the spaces between with the unhurried precision of people who had practiced this.

They drew geometric glowing symbols in the air and seeds began to shimmer and rise. They lifted from the bowls at the arc's edge, hundreds of them, climbing in a slow spiral that caught the morning light and held it. Each one glowed faintly as it rose, until the air above the platform was luminous with small moving lights. They turned slowly as they ascended.

Adora looked at Glimmer's face, upturned and bright with concentration and joy, the expression of doing something she loved with people she loved. Micah stood with his eyes soft and open. The crowd stared in awe.

The seeds reached their apex. They hung there for one suspended moment. Then they descended to the ground. They drifted slowly down. They reached the ground and burst into bloom.

Someone laughed, the bright unguarded kind. Then someone else. The sound moved through the crowd in a warm wave, laughter and tears arriving together the way they did when something was genuinely, unexpectedly beautiful.

The laughter kept coming and the sound of it began to arrive half a beat late. The colors of the blossoms were too vivid to focus on. Each breath she took began to feel too tight in her chest.

Her hands began to tingle. She saw a subtle glow by her nails that she tried to suppress. She clenched her hands into fists at her

sides, keeping them from trembling.

Adora saw movement to her side. Swift Wind's head had lifted sharply, his ears flattening and his wings drawing tight against his sides. His hooves shifted once against the stone, restless and wrong, like he wanted to bolt and was forcing himself to stay. He was not looking at the crowd. He was looking at the flowers.

The colorful blossoms continued to shimmer and unfurl. Each bloom grew fuller as vines rooted deeper into the ground beneath them. For half a breath, everyone in the crowd seemed to gasp in wonder.

Then the stems kept growing. Vines shot across the courtyard faster than wind, bright and green and alive, wrapping around lamps, banners, the base of the platform. Laughter cut off abruptly. Children were pulled back by parents.

There it was. The line she had been watching for all morning and had not seen until it was already behind them.

A frightened voice carried from the crowd, "Something is wrong."

Then another voice, almost angry, "That's not just restored magic."

Roots cracked through stone. The ground pulsed beneath the courtyard. For a moment the sound of it eclipsed even the ever-present rush of the waterfall.

People stumbled back, catching one another by the arms. Magic turned bright enough to make everyone wince. Many of the faces turned quickly toward her.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

She raised her sword toward the growth and it shook in her too-large, glowing hands. She had crossed into some greater fear now. Even She-Ra was not certainty. Even She-Ra did not make her hands stop trembling.

She didn’t know what to do. She didn’t know which choice would help and which would harm. She could do so much damage if she chose wrong. She felt like a hero should know the answers. She realized everyone else thought she knew.

Then Catra was there.

In front of her now, too close to be part of the crowd, too real to become another voice inside it. She did not look at the vines. She stepped into Adora’s line of sight and stayed there.

She-Ra’s hands still shook. Her voice was the lowest whisper, barely more than a trembling breath, “I don’t know what to do.”

“Adora. Look at me. Not the crowd. Not the whole planet. Me.”

They locked eyes. Adora matched Catra’s breathing. She solidified her stance.

The light around her changed, or maybe the light in the courtyard changed, or maybe the vines had already reached whatever they had been reaching for. They stopped advancing. The surge receded and calmed.

A loud sigh of relief filled the garden, like a collective exhale. Then a cheer spread through the crowd.

Glimmer reached her first, face pale with relief. Bow was right behind her. People were clapping now, crying, calling She-Ra like it had become a shield they could hold over themselves.

“You did it,” Glimmer said.

Adora looked past her at the vines, still bright against the cracked stone. Had she? Maybe the surge had just ended because surges ended.

She had transformed. Stood there with all that power and still not known what good was supposed to look like. The surge had stopped, yes, but stopping was not the same as helping. Not if

she could not tell whether she had steadied anything or only survived being useless until the danger passed.

The crowd cheered louder.

Adora smiled.

It was the same smile as before and yet it was different. The one during the speech had been reflexive, produced by the part of her that had learned early what was required when people said certain things. This one cost more. This one she had to build while standing in the wreckage of not knowing, while Glimmer held her hands and Bow's steadiness pressed into her shoulder, and the crowd continued its generous and entirely misplaced certainty.

Catra was the only one close enough to see that the smile did not reach her eyes.

Chapter 8: Restraint

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer asks that they respond to the surges together and with caution. At the waterways near Alwyn, Adora begins to wonder if that is enough.

The War Room felt different with everyone in it again. Adora had spent enough hours there alone recently with the maps and her pins that it had begun to feel like her own private space. Now, Glimmer stood at the head of the table once more, Bow on one side and Micah on the other. It reminded her of when they'd been coordinating the restoration work just after the war.

Entrapta also sat beside Bow scrolling through her data pad. Catra had angled her chair so she could see the map, the table and Adora without appearing to watch any of it. Her tail was moving in slow arcs that meant she was paying more attention than it initially appeared.

"We need a coordinated response," Glimmer said definitively. Clearly, she had been thinking about this since before entering the room. "People are going to have questions about what happened at the ceremony. We need to be ahead of the next surge, not reacting to it." She turned. "Entrapta, what information do we know?"

Entrapta's screen was covered in overlapping data visualizations that no one else in the room could understand without significant explanation. She held it up anyway, turning it so everyone could see. "Okay, so I've been mapping Etheria's magical fluctuations and surges and working on a predictive model. It isn't telling us why it's happening yet," she said with cheerful confidence, "but it is getting much better at guessing where it's going to happen next!"

Bow pulled up the visualization of the map of Etheria on the table and had Entrapta overlay her data. Bright Moon sat at the center of the activity, with other surges clustered in the nearest villages bordering the Whispering Woods. There was some outlying energy variance data showing in Plumeria and Dryl as well.

“Plumeria has some accelerated blooming but it might just be seasonal. It’s hard to distinguish from baseline there,” Entrapta noted. “Dryl’s readings spiked at the same time as the ceremony earlier, but I think the instruments may have been affected by the ceremony, not a separate surge itself. I’m recalibrating, but I would consider the data from Dryl as currently unreliable.”

Adora looked at the blank spaces between the marked surges. These were places where nothing had been reported yet. Something could already be going wrong there while they stood here talking.

“The map’s only useful if we keep updating it together,” Bow said simply.

Catra’s fingers brushed Adora’s sleeve. Adora registered the touch but didn’t turn toward her. She kept her gaze focused on the map visualization.

"No one responds alone," Glimmer said. "We use the map, we use Entrapta's model, and we keep each other updated. No exceptions."

Adora kept her face still. They were right that solo response had limits, which was why she needed to be even more careful, even more prepared, even more certain before acting, so that when she did act it would be correct.

"The other thing," Micah started carefully. “Unknown magic does not always respond well to force. We don't fully understand what's happening with these surges. We don't know the mechanism or the cause. Acting from a position of incomplete understanding,

with significant power…” he paused. "Sometimes the first act of protection is restraint."

The room was quiet.

"So we don't charge into every possible surge with everything we have," Glimmer said. She was nodding slowly, working it through. "We coordinate. We verify. We evacuate first. We respond second. And we use the minimum necessary force. No one becomes the single point of failure.”

Catra's tail stilled. She wasn’t looking at the map. She was looking at Adora.

Adora nodded. “Right,” she said. “Coordinated response. Verify before action. Restraint first.”

That made sense. She could mean well with every part of herself and still choose wrong. She could want only to help and still leave cracks behind, still frighten creatures into stillness, still make things harder for the people who had trusted her to know better.

Glimmer turned back to the map. “Entrapta, which sites is the model predicting as most likely to surge next?”

Entrapta reviewed the data on her pad. “The area near Thaymor, the waterways between Bright Moon and Alwyn, and Plumeria. In that order of probability, though I want to note that probability here means most likely based on current pattern, not most likely to be dangerous. Those are different metrics."

"Noted," Glimmer said. She studied the map for a moment. “I'll take Bow to Plumeria as it’s the furthest out." She looked at Micah. "You and Catra can go to Thaymor. It's close enough to the Woods that a sorcerer on site makes sense. Adora, that puts you and Entrapta at the waterways. We’ll each take a small guard detail.”

“That works,” Adora said.

Glimmer looked around the table. "We report back every hour. No one engages a surge without signaling first.”

They were filing out when Catra caught Adora’s elbow.

“Adora.”

Adora turned, already bracing.

Catra glanced toward the map, then back at her. “You heard what they were actually saying, right?”

Adora stiffened, “Yes. Coordinate. Observe. Use restraint.”

Catra’s ears were angled back, her face too still. “That’s what they said. Not what I asked.”

“I know what they meant, Catra,” Adora replied.

Catra’s tail moved once, low and sharp, then went still. She turned and caught back up with Micah.

Adora moved in step with Entrapta. She walked right beside her.

…

There was a slight hum in the air. Adora felt it first as they approached the predicted surge area, not much more than the usual always-present feel of Etheria’s magic since the release of the Heart. She’d learned to read it like she’d read the Fright Zone’s halls, the differences in the static feel of the silence before the shadows would appear.

They stood now beside a network of canals that carried water from the falls behind Bright Moon castle down into the lowlands that led into Alwyn’s farms. They were stone-built and precise. The water ran clear and cold in the midday light. It flowed down a stepped falls and into a main channel before splitting off into a series of irrigation canals.

Entrapta had her pad out, already scanning, her hair moving in the quick, purposeful patterns of someone who had found a good dataset and intended to extract everything from it. The guards fanned out along the waterways with quiet efficiency. They had been briefed and knew their job. One of them caught Adora's eye and gave a small nod. Everything was in order.

Adora nodded back and turned toward the main canal. Etheria's magic moved through the waterways the way electrical current did. It was always moving, had always been moving. She was only now standing still enough in the right place to feel how much.

Her chest tightened. She noticed her breathing going a bit shallow and deliberately made it slow. It was harder to keep it regular than it should have been.

She watched the water flow and tried to just conduct an assessment. She noticed the reflections on the water were trembling. The surface did not appear disturbed. The flow was steady. Still the water seemed to vibrate almost imperceptibly.

"Entrapta," she said. "Are you getting anything unusual in the readings?"

"Getting a lot of things," Entrapta said, without looking up. "Most of them interesting. Refining now."

The light off the water caught and released in patterns that were almost too rhythmic. The glare was too bright. Her focus jumped from each channel to the stepped falls and back again.

Her hands tingled. She pressed them flat against her thighs. The air tasted metallic. The hair on her arms stood up. The ambient magic of Etheria was humming, and her internal She-Ra magic was trying to answer back like a tuning fork.

Her magic was at her fingertips now, gold pressing under the skin. She tried to breathe through the rising glow to let it recede. She-Ra was too much. She needed to be less right now. Less power would mean less risk. She tried to force the gold down.

A low sound reached her ears and a thin crack appeared between mortar and stone along the side of a channel. Water began to move through it, a thin bright line of it, and then the crack widened and the thread became a stream as the water began to flow through the path of least resistance, building speed.

One of the guards was already moving, signaling the others.

Adora’s jaw clenched. Would she be able to help more as She-Ra? No, she had agreed not to just use power against surges they did not fully understand. She told herself to hold it in, but the pressure built anyway. It shifted through her, gathering inside her wrists, between her shoulder blades, and in the tight place at the base of her throat that had been there for days.

The water in the central channel began to rise. Then, in just one section, the current reversed. For several seconds the water ran upward against the grade, pushing up the falls in defiance of gravity. Sediment carried up each step.

She thought of Catra and how she’d helped her during the ceremony. She tried to calm her breathing on her own, but it stayed too quick. She felt heat rise under her skin. Her pounding heartbeat mixed with the pulsing of Etheria’s surging magic. For a moment the world tilted and blurred.

Then Entrapta was closer, focused on her pad and saying words Adora couldn’t make out. The guards had moved farther than she expected along the irrigation canals. The water in the central channel was running downstream again, the reversed section gone, the surface still trembling but differently, subsiding rather than building.

She didn’t know how long she had just been standing there. At least the glow had faded.

"The surge is subsiding," one of the guards reported. "The channel wall is damaged but contained. Two lower fields will have to be cut off until the mortar is reinforced. No injuries.”

"Good," Adora said. Her voice came out level. She was grateful for that.

Entrapta had not stopped scanning through any of it. She looked up now, her expression the one she wore when data had produced an unexpected result and she wasn't sure yet whether to be pleased.

"Okay, so," she said, "the readings just now were really interesting." She turned the pad so Adora could see, though the visualizations required more explanation than the gesture implied. "There's a resistance pattern. Within the magic itself. It's almost like…" she tilted her head, searching for the right frame, "like the magic is pushing back against itself. Or against something." She looked at the pad again. "I don't have a category for it yet. I'm going to need significantly more data. This is very exciting actually. I need to get more robust sensors to measure the next surge from the field."

Adora looked at the water. The channels ran clear and steady now. The guards had gotten everyone out of the nearest fields. They did exactly what they were supposed to do. It worked. Adora still didn't know what she had done.

The tingling had faded, but she could still feel its echo beneath her skin. There seemed to be some sort of connection between Etheria's magic and her magic rising. She realized now that not transforming wasn't enough. The surge had changed when she forced her magic down. At least she thought it had. That uncertainty was almost worse.

She needed to understand the connection. If it could hurt people or be dangerous then she needed to know more. She couldn't afford to just guess or hope. They could have a coordinated response to the surges, but no one else could feel what was happening between Etheria's magic and her own. That part was hers to understand. Before the next surge, she needed to be certain.

The water ran smoothly through the cracked channel. Beneath her skin, the answering hum had not entirely stopped. She couldn’t tell if it was a warning, a call, or an accusation.

Chapter 9: Resonance

Chapter Summary

> The Whispering Woods are alive with answers and echoes. Adora just needs to understand which ones are hers.

Adora did not head back to the castle but to the Woods instead. She needed to find somewhere safe and isolated, a place where she could try and understand. Something was wrong with Etheria's magic. It was surging beyond renewal and healing into instability. Had it been wounded somehow? Was it being manipulated?

What was the connection between Etheria's magic and her own magic rising? Whenever she felt Etheria's magic now, a hum beneath her feet or in the air around her, it seemed too intense. It made her feel too aware, and then suddenly She-Ra would try to rise unbidden. She needed to know what to do so she wouldn't make any more mistakes.

Adora moved deeper into the Whispering Woods, where the branches grew dense and the light barely broke through. She walked until the trail vanished beneath a carpet of moss, until she could no longer see the spires of Bright Moon through the canopy, until the only sounds were the ones that belonged to the Woods themselves.

A tiny winged insect clung to the dark bark of a nearby tree. Its body vibrated hard enough to tremble the nearest leaves. From deeper in the Woods, a similar buzz carried back on the wind. It was close enough to be an answer, different enough to be alive, a slightly off pitch that still harmonized.

Then the dense trees opened into a grassy clearing, perhaps twenty paces across, nearly circular. Wildflowers dotted the grass, clusters of violet Etherian bells and tiny pink star-lilies. At the far edge, a thin stream tumbled over smooth stones and the exposed

roots of the trees, carrying the same endless motion as the falls above Bright Moon but simpler.

This seemed like a good place for what Adora needed. It felt far enough away from others to be safe. There was nothing nearby to damage. No one would find her here. No one would watch her fail or flinch or lose control.

Adora stepped into the center of the clearing and turned slowly, confirming her solitude. The insects continued their call-and-response around her, the stream provided a liquid counterpoint, and somewhere high above a bird called out softly. She exhaled, feeling her shoulders drop for the first time in what felt like weeks.

“Pretty spot,” said a distinctive, aged voice directly behind her. “Quiet. For now.”

Madame Razz stood at the edge of the clearing, leaning on her old broom, her bracelets clinking, and her spectacle-enlarged eyes fixed on Adora.

“Razz.” Adora was startled but somehow unsurprised to see her suddenly there. “I'm trying to understand something.”

“Mm.” Razz moved closer, not toward Adora exactly, more in the direction of a particular patch of light. “The river doesn't understand the stone. It just finds the way around.”

“I need to know what's happening between my magic and Etheria's. I need to understand the connection so I can…”

“So you can hold it,” Razz said. It wasn’t a question.

Adora opened her mouth.

Razz looked at her then, not through her, but so directly it made Adora go still. “The roots don't hold the tree,” she said. “The roots and the tree hold each other. Different thing.” She reached out and patted Adora's hand once, her touch light.

“I need to understand what I'm doing before I make things worse. The surges in Alwyn, during the Blooming, and at the waterways… I'm connected to it, Razz. I can feel it. And if I can feel it, I should be able to…”

“You cannot listen to a stream by holding it in your fist, dearie,” Razz said. “If you touch the roots, the roots touch back, and a single root cannot tell you all that the garden knows.”

Adora looked over at where the stream ran past the exposed roots at the edge of the clearing, and when she looked back, Razz was gone, as if she had been a quality of the light and then the light had shifted. The insects continued their soft calls.

Adora stared again at the roots and the stream. She couldn’t force the connection. She understood that much. She needed to stay calm enough to feel it clearly and be ready for when Etheria responded. One root couldn’t explain the whole garden, so she would have to understand the entire system of her magic and Etheria’s, and every place they touched.

She settled onto her knees in the center of the small clearing. The light fell in a single golden shaft through a break in the canopy. Her hands hung open at her sides, palms forward. She let her weight settle back and tried to release the tension in her shoulders. She tried to make herself receptive.

Etheria’s magic was there before she reached for it, the ambient hum that had been in the air since the Heart released. She just let it be for a moment. The air smelled damp and clean. Ferns trembled at the clearing’s edge, their fronds stirred by a breeze she could barely feel against her face. Water moved softly over stone in the distance.

Her magic moved outward, and the hum beneath the soil shifted to meet it. Etheria breathed around her, with her, through her. She could feel the clearing as a collection of small living things, each separate and yet connected. Moss was drinking from the damp

stones, roots were pressing through dark soil, new leaves were folded tightly inside green buds. Relief loosened behind her ribs.

The connection had to stay stable. She needed to understand it well enough that when the next surge came, she would be able to keep herself from reacting, from making things worse.

The rhythm of the hum waxed and waned. There was a faster pulse that swelled through her and then a pause, almost like a hesitation that made her stomach drop. Variation was natural, she told herself. Still, she wondered if she was doing something to it. Had she made an error, failed to account for something she should have seen?

She needed to correct this. She had to find the exact edge, the point where connection became interference, where understanding became harm. If she could feel it before it happened, she could stop it, not just now, but the next time when a village was on the line and she needed to be the one who knew what to do.

The hum pulled taut in her chest. She reached into the connection the way she reached for her sword. When she tightened her focus, the hum tightened back. The roots around her tensed. The stream kept tumbling over the stones, but the sound thickened in her ears until it was no longer a trickle, no longer just a thread of water winding through the Woods, but a rush too large to separate from the hum beneath her skin.

She pushed toward the change, searching for the place where the shift had begun, but the connection only sharpened around her attention. The pulse came faster. The roots drew tighter. Every flicker of uncertainty returned to her magnified, as if the Woods were asking the same questions as her. Was it reacting to her? Or was she reacting to it? She could no longer tell, and she needed to find the difference. She needed to know which part was hers before she made it worse. She needed to be certain before it became something she couldn’t stop.

Her heartbeat no longer seemed separate from the pulse in the ground. The roots shuddered beneath her and the shudder passed into her bones. Heat flashed beneath her skin, sudden and deep, as if it had ignited inside her. Glowing gold threaded along her fingers and climbed her arms. She gasped, and everything blurred.

Adora blinked. Her hands were raised in front of her now. She didn't remember lifting them.

The light in the clearing had changed, shadows angling differently across the ground. How long? Her heart slammed against her ribs.

The grass in a rough circle around her was scorched, pale and flattened where it had been green and soft. Two cracks ran through the exposed dirt, thin and definitive, radiating outward from where her knees met the ground. The moss at the clearing's edge had curled back, leaving the nearest tree roots exposed in the disturbed soil.

She was trembling, she realized almost distantly. Had she caused this or contained it? She dragged air into her lungs, but it stopped high in her chest.

The world blurred at the edges. She blinked, but the trees only smeared farther into green and black. Her pulse was everywhere. It was in her throat, behind her eyes, under the hot skin of her wrists.

"Adora!" The shout came from far away, distorted by the rush of blood in her ears. She tried to turn toward it and the world tilted.

She felt a rush of air as Swift Wind landed abruptly. Catra was already leaping off his back before his hooves had fully touched down, landing in a crouch. They both froze for a moment. Then Catra crossed the clearing in three strides, dropping to her knees in front of Adora and putting both hands on her face.

"Hey." Catra's voice was tight and frightened and trying not to be. "Hey. Look at me."

Swift Wind's wings were still half-spread. He was looking at the scorched grass and then at Adora. His ears stiffened.

"Adora, I felt your distress," Swift Wind said, his voice low and strained, not his usual bright tone. "A wrongness in the bond."

Adora tried to speak. Her tongue felt thick and uncooperative. "M'fine," Adora managed weakly. "You just… felt feedback. In the magic."

"No. It was you."

Catra's face had paled beneath her fur. Her blue and gold eyes were wide. "He came tearing onto our balcony saying something was wrong with you."

"Something was wrong," Swift Wind said.

Catra's ears pinned flat, and her hand shook once before she curled it into a fist.

"What were you doing, Adora? What were you thinking?" Catra's voice was sharp, but her hands shook. Her tail lashed once, then curled close to her own leg. One hand slid from Adora's cheek to the side of her neck. Her palm was cool against Adora's overheated skin. "Don't tell us you're fine. You're shaking. You're burning."

"It's just the magic." Adora tried to straighten, to prove she could hold herself together.

"Oh, good," Catra snapped. "That makes this so much better." She gently checked Adora's pulse, then wiped the sweat from her brow.

Adora swayed. Catra quickly wrapped an arm around her before she could fall, claws held carefully back.

Swift Wind moved closer. His hooves struck the ground in short, restless movements.

“I don’t know how to reach you,” Catra said, the sharpness in her voice cracking slightly, rawness showing through. “You don’t get to disappear into this and call it helping.”

“I won’t do it again,” Adora said. She meant it. At least she wanted to mean it.

Catra nodded once, but her grip stayed firm, like she was afraid Adora might vanish if she let go.

Swift Wind folded his legs beneath him and lowered his body to the ground. Catra guided Adora back against his flank before her shaking knees could object. His warmth pressed along her spine, his body solid behind her and rhythmic with every breath.

Catra settled beside her, shoulder firm against Adora’s, one arm wrapped around her waist. When another tremor pulled through her, Swift Wind’s wing curved closer, and Catra adjusted her grip without speaking.

Adora could feel them all around her. Swift Wind’s breathing behind her. Catra’s steady heartbeat beneath the fingers Adora had somehow curled around her wrist. The faint vibration still moving through the ground below. She heard the sounds of the Woods coming back to itself around the clearing, the water over the distant stones, the birds reclaiming the silence she had disturbed.

She had come here to understand what was hers alone. Now Swift Wind had felt it from Bright Moon. Catra had been dragged into the Woods because of her.

Adora closed her eyes. She had messed up. She didn't deserve this care, this gentleness. Still, Catra’s arm stayed around her and Swift Wind held steady beside her.

She had only needed to do one thing right. That was all. One calm connection without making it worse. Instead she had lost control of it, and Catra had found her shaking on the ground like something broken.

She needed to do better, to be steadier, more stable, more certain, easier for them. Her body sagged against Swift Wind's side anyway. She let herself be held, though she thought about all the ways she needed to be different.

Chapter 10: Composure

Chapter Summary

> Adora tries to stay steady through the next report, the next conversation, and the next surge. Catra asks her to try differently.

The room was still dim, with the first light of morning coming through the two large arched windows that balanced the space. Adora had slid carefully out of bed, making sure not to wake Catra or disturb the curtain. Then she had set about getting ready for the meeting, determined to be calm and prepared, her best self.

She'd pushed through the slight lingering soreness from the events of the day before. She could still feel the phantom pressure of Catra's arm locked around her waist on the flight back, the wind cold against her face, Catra's grip tight. Her earlier words, "I don't know how to reach you," echoed in her mind. She would be easier to reach today, steady. She'd be what everyone needed.

Now Adora stood in front of the mirror, morning light flooding in more fully as she pulled up her hair into its standard ponytail and poof with an almost mechanical precision. She smiled a few times, rehearsing it. She tried to get the expression just right to show she was fine now.

The bed shifted behind her and Adora didn't turn around.

"How long've you been up?" Catra's voice was rough with sleep.

"Not long." Adora made it sound casual. She kept her hands busy with her belt, threading it through the loops of her jacket and tightening it through the clasp with precise, deliberate motions.

Catra looked her up and down. "Right." Her ears dipped, just for a second.

Adora watched in the mirror as Catra sat up, the sheets pooling at her waist, her hair sticking up in every direction. She didn't move to get out of bed immediately. Instead, she sat there, tail flicking once against the mattress, her eyes tracking over Adora's reflection with the kind of slow assessment that made Adora feel like she needed to adjust her collar or her stance.

Adora waited for Catra to question her further. Instead, Catra swung her legs over the side of the bed and stood, stretching fully, her tail curling and uncurling. She padded across the room, not toward Adora but past her, close enough that Adora could smell her familiar, sweet almost musky scent.

“War Room in five,” was all Catra said as she moved about the room readying herself quickly.

Adora nodded and smoothed her jacket, checking her reflection one last time.

Catra dressed in silence, efficient and economical in her movements. She didn't look at Adora again, not directly, but Adora felt the weight of her attention anyway.

Once ready, Catra pulled the door open and the sounds of the castle filtered in, boots on stone, distant voices, the ordinary rhythms of a kingdom that had rebuilt itself. Adora followed her into the hallway.

Catra fell into step beside her, close enough that their shoulders almost brushed. They walked without speaking, passing guards who straightened and saluted and aides who stepped aside with murmured greetings. Adora nodded to each of them, easy and steady, her best self.

At the War Room doors, Catra stopped. She caught Adora's wrist before she could reach for the handle. Her grip was light, just fingertips and thumb, but it stopped Adora in her tracks.

Catra just looked at her for a half-beat longer than necessary, then opened the door. “After you.”

Adora moved into the room with purpose, her posture straight, her gait even. She took her seat carefully, folded her hands on the polished surface, and looked up at Glimmer with an overly calm expression. The projected map was still lit on the table and Glimmer stood at its head with her lips parted and her eyebrows raised like she already had information she was ready to share.

"Reports came in overnight," she said, without preamble. "Perfuma sent a message. She felt a disturbance yesterday, like a wave moving through the root system. She said it felt like something passed beneath Plumeria. Like the ground flinched." She paused.

Adora kept her face still. "Any structural damage?" Her voice came out level. That was good. She tried to keep her shoulders loose.

"No. Just… odd. And Scorpia wrote from the Scorpion Kingdom."

Bow looked up from his tracker pad.

"They saw something too," Glimmer said. "The former Fright Zone territories. Scorpia described it as the ground humming. Plants coming up through the floors of buildings. Nothing harmful yet. She wasn't alarmed. I am."

Adora nodded, measured and thoughtful. "Sounds like localized magical instability." Her voice was steady, the perfect pitch of a commander assessing a minor concern. "Have we seen this before?"

"Not exactly," Glimmer said slowly.

Catra had taken the seat to Adora's left. She sat back in her chair, one leg crossed over the other, her arms loosely folded. She didn't look at Adora. She looked at the map, at Bow, at the murals, but Adora could feel the attention anyway. When Adora spoke the first time, Catra's ear twitched. The second time, her tail flicked once against the chair leg.

"Entrapta has more." Bow held up his tracker pad.

Entrapta's face appeared, her hair already reaching toward the camera with curious tendrils. "Dryl's experiencing similar anomalous readings. Minor fluctuations in the local magical field. Very minor. But!" She held up a finger, grinning. "I cross-referenced the timestamps with the reports from Plumeria and the Scorpion Kingdom. Fascinating. The anomalies in all three locations appear to be echoes."

"Echoes?" Glimmer leaned forward.

"Yes. Residual ripples from the two larger surges yesterday, one at the waterways and another I detected in the Whispering Woods. And in both cases, the readings afterward showed something I've been calling an echo. A residual pattern that wasn't present before the surge."

The room went quiet. Adora felt Catra shift beside her, a nearly imperceptible adjustment of weight. Adora didn't blink. She forced her shoulders to stay relaxed. She looked at the map, at the indicators over Bright Moon and the Whispering Woods and now Plumeria and the Scorpion Kingdom. The cluster of magical incidents had begun to spread outward from where the surges had been the day before, the magic echoing beyond the initial surge point. Adora kept her expression calm.

"So it's changing," Glimmer said.

"The system is changing. Yes. Each surge is leaving something behind." Entrapta looked back at her screen. "I don't know yet what it's leaving. But the echoes are consistent now, which means whatever it is, it's not local. It's systemic."

"We monitor for now," Glimmer said. "We collect more data. I'll ask the kingdoms to report even minor magical anomalies. We should make sure the Woods continue to be patrolled."

"Entrapta, keep us updated on any new surge data you detect," Bow added.

"Of course! This is very exciting!" Entrapta's screen winked out.

Adora let her hands unclasp, spreading them flat on the table in a gesture of open confidence. “Anything else?”

“No,” Glimmer said. “That’s everything.”

“Good.” Adora stood, smooth and unhurried.

She turned toward the door, her spine straight, her steps even. She could feel Catra rising behind her, could feel her presence like a hand at the back of her neck, but she didn’t look back. She kept her face forward, her breathing steady, her best self held carefully in place.

Behind her, Catra fell into step. Not beside her this time, right behind. Close enough to reach her, Adora realized if she decided to do so. She didn’t.

They were barely back in their room when Catra closed the door and turned toward her.

"You were performing in there," Catra said.

“I was being calm.”

"The voice you were using. The way you were sitting. The face,” Catra said, her voice tight. "You've been doing it since you woke up."

“I'm trying to be steady, Catra. I'm trying to not…” she stopped. "I’m trying to be better. To be easier. You said you didn’t know how to reach me…”

“So your answer is to disappear behind a smile?” Catra’s voice hardened. “You disappeared into the Woods yesterday. Now you’re standing right in front of me and doing it again. Just saying all the right things so nobody gets worried. I’m not gonna help you pretend you’re fine.”

Adora stared at her.

“You keep saying you’re trying, but you’re only trying to look like you’re okay when you’re not. I need you to actually let me in. Try doing this different, Adora.” Catra sounded desperate now.

“I don't know how to be different than I am.” Adora’s voice started to crack. “Even if my heart is in the right place, it is still not good enough when I keep doing this wrong.”

Adora felt her eyes burn, the pressure building behind them, the careful wall she’d spent all morning constructing crumbling at the foundation. She tried to hold it. She tried to breathe through it. But tears slipped over her lashes, hot and traitorous, one after another, and she couldn’t stop them.

Catra made a soft sound. She closed the distance and hugged her tightly.

Adora’s stiff posture softened into the warmth of Catra’s embrace, though she knew she didn’t deserve it. Her hands came up slowly and wrapped around Catra’s back, gripping the fabric there. She was heavy in Catra’s arms, all need and no give, the same pattern again. Catra had found her trembling in the Woods, had held her on Swift Wind, and now Adora was still taking, still collapsing, still asking for more.

She had promised to be easier, better, steadier and here she was needing to be held again. Crying meant Catra had to manage her crying. Adora couldn't even hold herself together through a single conversation.

“Having my heart in the right place is never enough for this world,” Adora whispered against Catra’s shoulder. “It's just never enough. I’m not doing this right.” The thoughts wouldn’t stop and the quiet words kept stuttering out in bits, “I’m just doing everything wrong…“

“Adora,” Catra said.

Adora heard her name, but couldn’t quite stop, “I’m just failing… failing at everything.”

Catra held her for one more breath. Then her arms loosened slowly. “I love you, but you’re not hearing me like this,” she said, voice rough. “I need a minute.”

Then Catra slipped out the door and it closed behind her.

Adora was alone. She sank onto the bed, the hot tears still coursing down her cheeks. She wrapped her arms around herself and curled inward.

Adora felt the absence painfully. It was different than being alone. She had been choosing to be alone for days. Now Catra was choosing to be elsewhere. She felt like she had broken everything. Why would Catra even want to be with her when she failed so badly at making things work and meeting her needs?

Maybe she should just stay here until she had herself fully under control, wait until she knew exactly what to say. It felt responsible at first, but it was also what she had been doing all morning, trying to make herself easier. Catra had not asked her to disappear until she could make herself perfect.

Catra had been trying to reach her over and over, and Adora, so tangled in her own failure, had turned every attempt into proof that she was a burden. Catra had asked to be let in, and Adora had answered by making Catra reassure her. Adora didn’t know how to stop feeling like she had ruined everything, but maybe she did not have to make Catra argue with the feeling for her.

She drew in a shaky breath and let it out slowly. She wiped the tears from her cheeks. Then she got up, splashed some water on her face and went to find her. She knew where Catra would be.

Catra was on the eastern parapet, which was one of her usual places, high up and with a clear sightline. She was sitting on the edge with her legs hanging down. Melog curled against one side.

Adora climbed up, hesitating before she sat beside her. Neither of them spoke for a moment. Below, the grounds spread out in the late morning light, the gardens and the paths and the distant tree

line of the Whispering Woods. The waterfall caught the morning and threw it back as mist.

“I’m sorry,” Adora said, her voice rough and stripped of performance. “For not being able to hear you. You were telling me what you needed, and I made it about how I wasn’t enough.”

"Yeah," Catra said. "You did."

"I want to try differently,” Adora said quietly.

"What does trying differently look like?" Catra asked.

Adora thought about it. “I don’t know how to fix it yet. But I was going to go back to the Woods, and I don’t want to go without you again.”

Catra looked at her for a long moment, reading her like she always did, all the way through.

"Okay," she said. "But if you start disappearing while I'm standing right next to you, I'm gonna say something."

“I know.” Adora nodded. “I’ll try to tell you when I notice.”

Catra held her gaze for another moment. Then she looked back out at the Woods and something in her shoulders eased, slightly, not all the way.

They climbed down and headed out of the castle and toward the Woods. The air was crisper outside the walls. They walked together this time. Catra right beside her, their fingers laced, rough and real.

The Woods received them with the hush of a place that had seen a great deal and had long since stopped commenting on it. Adora felt the magic first in her feet, the ambient hum of it, threading up through the soil and roots and into the soles of her boots. It was very present, as it had been since the Heart.

She needed to handle this correctly with Catra beside her. She wanted to tell Catra enough that she wouldn't feel shut out, but she needed to keep things from unraveling too much. She wanted to do this together without her becoming a burden again.

"I feel it. Etheria's magic," Adora said quietly. "It's here, all around us."

Catra stopped beside her. "Okay."

Adora tried to find the words to describe it. "It's like standing next to a large creature and feeling its breath displacing the air all around you. Like a tingling rising through the ground and on the air, humming everywhere, with me, through me."

Catra was listening intently, her eyes locked on Adora.

"When I feel it, my magic responds," Adora said, barely above a whisper. "It starts to rise on its own."

"What does that feel like?"

"Like…" The gold was already there now, faint at her fingertips. She stared at her hands. "It's like that. Warmth pressing." Adora's chest tightened and her breaths shallowed.

Catra's hand remained around hers. Adora became suddenly conscious of every place their skin touched. Catra could feel her pulse. She could feel how fast it was becoming. Adora tried to slow it. She felt the magic tighten.

Catra looked at her.

Adora's fear sharpened. "Catra," Adora called out. She could feel heat rising now beneath her skin. Gold was coursing up her arms.

"Hey. Still here," Catra said.

Adora felt the squeeze of Catra's hand and the tightening worsened as Adora willed it to help and yet it didn't. At the

Blooming ceremony, Catra had steadied her, but now all Adora could think about was how she was still messing this up and Catra could tell and nothing about that felt steadying.

Their hands untwined. Adora was having trouble focusing. Everything seemed too close and too far away at once.

“Adora, tell me what’s happening?”

The words were hard to grasp onto. “I’m trying to… it’s hard to...”

The air around them thickened. The undergrowth shuddered. A sound moved through the trees like a wave moving through water. It wasn't the wind. Thin cracks spread across the ground.

Adora couldn’t tell anymore where the magic ended and she began. The golden glow surrounded her completely, the brightness overwhelming.

Her hands were too big. She realized she had transformed unbidden. They trembled and she couldn’t stop it.

Catra stared wide-eyed for half a breath. Then her jaw set.

“I didn’t mean to do that.” Adora’s voice barely had sound.

“I know,” Catra said. Her voice was steady. Her hands were at her sides, one of them curled slightly, claws just visible, the tell she couldn't quite suppress when frightened. "I saw."

Adora had wanted to do this right. She had climbed up to the parapet and apologized and asked Catra to come and meant every word of it and it had still gone like this. She hadn’t disappeared this time. She'd told Catra what she was feeling as she was feeling it, and She-Ra had arrived anyway and the magic had surged anyway and Catra had had to stand here and watch it happen.

She was the thing happening to Catra. She had been trying not to be, and she still was.

“I… I shouldn’t be struggling this much.” Adora’s voice trembled with the admission.

“Yeah, well, power’s not exactly the same thing as being okay,” Catra said softly.

Adora nodded, but she couldn’t quite take that in. That morning, she had thought she understood how to stand, how to breathe, how to set her face. She had believed she could be steady. Now even that understanding was gone.

Catra was still there, watching her with those careful eyes. Adora did not know whether that made the fear better or worse. She stood in the Woods with the magic surging through her and all around her, with no way left to compose herself into someone who knew what to do. This time, she did not say that she was fine.

Chapter 11: Consequence

Chapter Summary

> Magic is echoing across Etheria, and every attempt Adora makes has an unanticipated effect.

The magic did not stop all at once. It loosened around Adora in uneven pulses, the pressure receding from her chest while the trees continued to tremble. Light passed through the roots in small waves that rippled outward as the surge ended.

The golden glow faded from her body leaving a hollow feeling. Her limbs were heavy. “We should check the perimeter. I should try…”

“Guards have the perimeter,” Catra countered and then softened a bit, “There’s nothing more that you can do here right now. Let’s head back.”

Adora looked around, taking in the faintly cracked ground surrounded by the undergrowth. She wanted to fix this. She wanted to understand how to stop it from happening again. She couldn't right now, so she turned and followed Catra back to the castle.

At the edge of the Woods, where the trees gave way to the waters of Bright Moon, she saw it. The moonstone, hovering in front of the castle, flickered. The waterfall cascading behind it pulsed instead of flowing smoothly.

Adora stopped walking for a moment and stared. Catra had stopped beside her as well. Etheria’s magic was reacting all around her, and she still did not know how to fix it. Neither said anything and after a moment they kept walking along the path.

The messages were waiting when they reached the castle. Bow met them with his tracker pad already open, his expression conveying urgency without panic. “Reports are coming in from

multiple locations," he spoke quickly but kept his voice level. "Plumeria, Thaymor, the Scorpion Kingdom. Entrapta's calling them echoes again, but she says they're stronger than the previous ones, and there might be some damage."

"What's the most urgent?" Adora asked.

"Thaymor had the strongest levels."

"We'll head there now," Adora said, "Catra, Swift Wind…"

"I'm already here," Swift Wind said from the courtyard entrance. His tone and demeanor were much more measured than his typical entrance.

Catra looked at Adora for a long moment, ears angled back. Adora could see the argument she was not making while people might be in danger. Catra then said, "Let's go."

Bow handed them a data pad to keep everyone in the loop. It felt solid in Adora's hand, steadying to know she'd have the data she needed even if the problems seemed to be growing larger.

…

By the time Swift Wind landed in Thaymor, the surge was apparent. There was new growth blooming too aggressively in multiple locations. Cracked walls knit themselves back together with living green seams. Every lingering scar of past Horde occupation was being sealed with overzealous new growth, beautiful and frightening at once.

Catra's ears were flat and she stayed close to Adora.

Adora felt the strong hum of magic all around and through her. Before she had even dismounted she found herself breathless and unable to keep focus well. Gold tingled at her fingertips.

Blossoms had opened along all the old cracks in the village commons, tracing the path of a blast Adora had not seen in years

but still recognized. She stared too long. She had stood at the center of this village and made a choice. She had turned away from one life and toward another.

“Adora. It’s not that day,” Catra said from right beside her. Her ears were pinned even as her voice stayed steady.

This was old damage. Adora understood damage. She could fix damage. She could feel Catra beside her, hear Swift Wind shifting behind them, but a rounded roof was cracking nearby. There would be time to explain after she kept it from falling.

“For the honor of Grayskull.”

Adora transformed quickly to stabilize the roof, to control the growth so it would repair safely. That had to be the best thing to do, right? She-Ra’s hands appeared before her, large and glowing, trying to help yet still trembling.

For a moment it seemed to work as the roof stopped buckling. She needed to do this right, to keep the roof from collapsing on anyone. The plants already growing in the cracks accelerated wildly, sealing too fast. Roots pulled tighter. Echoes of light rippled outward. Structurally, the building had been stabilized, but the repair felt wrong, not healed but strained. At least the villagers were safe for now.

The data pad vibrated with an alert and Catra called out, “Plumeria needs help. The magic is too much for Perfuma alone.”

She-Ra nodded and they remounted Swift Wind quickly. The transformation tugged at her, asking to be released, but reports were still arriving. Letting She-Ra go while there was more to fix felt impossible.

…

As they approached Plumeria they could see excessive blooming damaging structures. Flowers covered surfaces in layers that had

gone from decorative to compressive. The weight of them was pressing on the older buildings.

Perfuma was helping near a set of homes. On the other side of the village, vines had wrapped around and were cracking apart a bridge. Roots tightened around the base supports, blossoms weighed down the structure, and vines threaded into the joints pulling inward.

Adora believed she had pushed too hard in Thaymor and strained the magic. Here she would be gentler, not force it back. She needed to get this right. She turned to Catra who was beside her and said, as though trying to convince herself, "I have to try to ease it."

Catra went very still, but didn't interrupt.

Adora reached for the smallest thread of magic she could feel. She would be careful enough to be safe, exact enough not to make the same mistake twice. She reached gently, but beneath was the same tight urgency. The bridge had to stop breaking. She had to make it stop.

The roots stilled for a second and then the whole vine went tense. The leaves turned toward her, then away and the blossoms closed. The bridge stopped cracking.

Catra was watching her, not the surge. The root network tensed as she tensed, but the bridge stabilized. Adora could barely separate the root pulse from her own heartbeat. A wave of dizziness hit her, but she steadied herself against it.

Perfuma had moved closer, her voice gentle and without accusation as she said, "It felt like the roots just braced."

Catra glanced from Perfuma to Adora.

Adora stared. Had she caused that? The pad in Catra's hand buzzed with alerts. Adora reached for it and read through them. Mermista was reporting that the tides in Salineas had started

acting oddly and Frosta that flowers were blooming under ice and starting to crack it. Scorpia needed help stabilizing damage in the old Fright Zone area along the border of her new kingdom.

There was now always another report, another place she had not reached yet, another consequence she might still prevent if she moved quickly enough.

“We’re needed in the Fright Zone,” Adora said, already moving toward Swift Wind.

She mounted slower than she wanted, her body dragging a bit. Catra said something and she barely tracked it. The roots’ tension continued in her body even after they had risen into the clouds.
…

The hum from Plumeria had followed her into the air. As the familiar jagged edges of the Fright Zone came into view, she could no longer tell whether the vibration came from Etheria or from inside her own bones. Adora’s hearing narrowed around the hum. Her vision blurred at the edges.

Swift Wind banked hard above the broken roofline, wings flaring. For one breath he did not descend.

“Swift Wind?” Catra snapped.

“The magic feels wrong,” he said, voice tight. “Etheria’s. She-Ra’s. It’s loud. Strained.”

Adora was conflicted. Swift Wind had hesitated, but they needed to try and stop the surge from harming anyone. Didn’t they? Was she even helping? She didn’t say her thoughts aloud. She tried to just get a grip on herself.

Swift Wind began to dive down and landed where the old Fright Zone bordered the new Scorpion Kingdom. They dismounted and entered the nearby building where the magic was surging.

Growth had come up through the ground with purpose but here it met Horde construction, fitted metal panels and spaces designed for function rather than life. Now the magic was finding every crack, every seam, every place that had been built without thought for what lived below. It was the magic of a living world reclaiming something that had refused it for a very long time, and it was doing so with the accumulated force of everything that had been denied.

Adora had grown up here. She had learned what she owed and what she couldn't be and what she had to become. She had faced the daily training courses and she still felt the memory of Shadow Weaver's silhouette in the halls.

Etheria was reclaiming it more than ever now, but with too much sudden force. The metal panel cracked with the pressure. Vines pushed through vents and machinery hummed now with magic instead of electricity. Adora wondered for a moment if she should even be trying to stop Etheria here.

Catra stayed right beside Adora. Her claws released and retracted repeatedly.

A walkway up above them and against one wall started to buckle from the impeding growth. People shouted as it destabilized beneath them, workers, maybe helping to build out the Scorpion Kingdom. Even if it was right for Etheria to take this back, she couldn’t let people get hurt. She-Ra lunged to keep it from collapsing.

She put her hands on the nearest support and pushed her power toward the growth inside it, trying to find the same solution she'd found at the bridge, to redirect, not remove, make space for the magic to go somewhere that wasn't structural. She held it like she had held herself for the entire day, with everything she still had left.

For a few seconds it worked, long enough for everyone to clear it. Then, the magic resonated harder with her. The old metal

groaned, plants burst through cracks, and the hum spread through the structure as it split.

The hum surged through Adora and she was suddenly unsteady on her feet. She-Ra flickered, then flared back too brightly. Her vision blurred. She felt the press of Catra's hand against her back for a brief moment.

"Adora," Catra said, her voice low. She wasn't looking at the walkway anymore. She was looking at She-Ra's trembling hands. "That's enough," she said sharply before desperation cut in. "Please. Don't push like this."

She could stop. Catra was asking her to stop. Even Swift Wind had felt something wrong before they landed. But the structure was groaning, and people were still close. Stopping now would mean allowing something to break while she still had power left. Adora did not know how to choose that.

The metal groaned in the same rhythm as the hum under her skin, plants burst through cracks all around the structure, the whole place seemed to answer She-Ra too loudly. She could not even help repair the place that made her. A sudden thought came sharp and unwanted, maybe everything she touched became damage. The surge around her intensified. She tried to pull back, to gentle it the way she had at the bridge, but she was too afraid of failing, too aware of Catra watching, of the workers still close.

The pad vibrated again. "Glimmer's calling everyone back," Catra said, her voice carefully neutral. "Full Alliance meeting. Now."

Swift Wind looked at Adora. He didn't say anything. His ears were half-back.

"Okay," Adora said quietly.

She followed Catra to Swift Wind and climbed on. They flew back to Bright Moon. Below them, the hum continued to pulse, and Adora felt every beat of it in her chest.

…

The princesses stood stiffly around the War Room table. Glimmer was at its head, brow furrowed, lips pressed into a thin line of grim resignation. Catra stood on one side of Adora, close but not touching and Swift Wind on the other. Mermista looked impatient and not pleased. Frosta stood arms crossed, face controlled. Perfuma was composed and careful.

Bow had mapped the surges in red and the echoes in spreading amber onto the projected map of Etheria. Entrapta had overlaid them with She-Ra's movements in gold. She leaned into the projection, her face bright with focus. The strongest destabilizations clearly clustered around places where She-Ra had been.

Mermista leaned forward and spoke with an almost weary frustration, "If every place she shows up gets worse, we have to stop pretending that's not a pattern."

Catra's tail stilled. Her ears flattened. Her claws caught against the table.

Adora looked at the map, at the gold markers and the amber spreading from each one.

Frosta spoke next in a careful tone, "She-Ra does not enter my kingdom until we know she won't crack the ice."

Catra bristled. "She's standing right here." She looked from face to face. "Funny how everyone loved having She-Ra fix things when the world was ending." Her voice sharpened and her claws flexed. "She's been out there all day keeping people safe. She's not just some faulty weapon."

"This doesn't mean Adora is causing it on purpose," Bow said. "It means the connection is amplifying something we don't understand."

Glimmer spoke carefully, "No one is saying Adora wanted this." She looked at the map, then at Adora. "But wanting to help

doesn’t mean we can keep sending She-Ra into every surge. Until we know why this is happening, I think She-Ra needs to…”

“Stand down,” Adora cut in. Her voice was calm. “I agree. If me being there is making it worse, then I shouldn’t be there.”

Catra’s head snapped toward Adora. She went still so suddenly that even her tail stopped its motion. She looked stricken.

“This isn’t permanent,” Perfuma said gently.

Adora nodded immediately. “Of course.”

She dropped her transformation. The light receded from her hands last and she stared for a moment at her smaller, no longer glowing hands.

Swift Wind’s ears lifted. The amber markers dimmed. The low vibration beneath the floor softened. The room relaxed by a fraction, though Catra didn’t. Catra reached for her. Adora stepped back before she meant to. She wasn't sure she was solid enough to be touched. Catra’s hand stopped in the space between them.

Etheria had quieted. Adora understood it as an answer.

Chapter 12: Verdict

Chapter Summary

Adora returns to her room to process. Catra stays with her.

The War Room was silent behind her, but Adora felt the weight of every stare pressing, her own gaze still locked on the map.

"Is the meeting over?" Her voice came out flat. "I'd like to go to my room."

No one answered quickly. No one seemed to know whether permission would make it better or worse.

Glimmer hesitated. "Yes, of course you can, if that's what you want."

Adora didn't look up. She walked toward the doors with her gaze fixed on the polished floor, counting the glints of reflection because it gave her something to do that wasn't thinking.

In the hall, the sky beyond the windows had darkened. It was heavy with clouds that swallowed the last of the daylight. She counted each arch.

Catra fell into step beside her.

Adora kept her hands at her sides. They felt too heavy, too present. They were the same hands that had held a sword, channeled light, left gold markers bleeding into amber across a map of a world she'd only ever wanted to save. She couldn't reach for Catra with them, not now.

She entered the room. It felt unnaturally quiet, like held breath. Even the waterfall sounded hushed, as if Etheria itself had lowered its voice to a whisper. Adora stood in the center of the room, unsure what to do next.

Catra's tail lashed once, then stilled. Her voice was low. "You should change into something more comfortable."

Adora went to the wardrobe, pulled out the first soft things her fingers found, and changed with mechanical efficiency. Catra handed her a glass of water and a piece of fruit. She sat where Catra pointed her. Adora ate without tasting it and drank without really feeling the weight of the glass in her hand. Catra knew what she needed even when she couldn't remember herself.

"I understand why they did it," Adora said. The words came surprisingly easily, like they'd been waiting in her throat. "It makes sense. I'm not upset with anyone."

Catra's ears were flat, her pupils wide in the dim light. "Adora…"

"I'm really not," she repeated, her voice calm. "They have to protect people. That's the whole point. If I'm the thing that's hurting them, then standing down is the right choice. It's the only choice."

Catra took a step closer. Adora shifted back, just an inch, but it was enough. Catra stopped. Her hand hovered in the air between them, then curled back against her side.

"Come here," Catra said, her voice rough. "Please. Just… let me…"

"I'm fine right here."

"You're not fine." Catra's claws flexed against her thighs. Her tail was rigid.

"I need to think," Adora said. "I need to go through it. All of it. If I don't think it through now, I'll just… I'll find a way to make it not my fault. I'll tell myself I was helping, that my intentions were good, and then I don't have to look at what actually happened." She paused. The quiet of the room pressed against her eardrums. She stood and began to pace. "I can't evade responsibility again, Catra. I can't."

Catra's jaw tightened. "Adora, maybe you should just lie down. You've been up for…"

"I can't sleep." The words came out sharper than she intended, and she heard the crack in her own voice. She pressed her palms against her thighs until her hands stopped shaking. "I can't. If I sleep, I stop knowing. I stop… I let go. And I can't let go right now. Not while I know what I know."

A fine crack running along the plaster in the wall widened. They both stared at it.

"What do you think you know?"

Adora laughed, and it was a hollow, broken sound. "That I was wrong. About all of it. I thought if I just helped enough people, saved enough places, proved it enough times, I could be certain I was good. That I could finally believe it. But I was looking at it backwards." She lifted her hands, staring at the empty palms. "But what if I did prove something? Just not what I thought I was proving? Every time I tried to fix something, I made it worse. The map proved it. Etheria proved it. I'm the destabilizing force. That's not a theory. That's not me being hard on myself. That's just… what happened."

Vines outside the balcony tightened around the rail. Catra's ears tilted toward them.

"The map calmed," Catra said, and her voice was fierce, almost angry, but her hands were trembling. "The map calmed when you transformed back. That doesn't mean you're what your head is making you into."

The list rose in her throat, each entry sharp and undeniable, a ledger she'd been keeping without knowing it. "Moorlet," Adora said quietly. "The Blooming. The Woods. Thaymor. Plumeria. The Fright Zone." She ticked them off on her fingers, one by one. "Every time I tried to help, something happened. Every single

time. You can’t look at that pattern and tell me it’s coincidence. You can’t tell me it’s not me.”

The air felt pressurized and difficult to breathe. Adora felt the hum of Etheria’s magic around and through her. Catra’s ears flattened completely. She crossed the distance between them in two strides and caught Adora’s wrist, her grip firm, grounding.

“You’re making a list again,” Catra said. Her thumb moved once across the inside of Adora's wrist. “You don’t have to sleep. Fine, stay awake. But at least sit with me on the bed and stop pacing.”

Adora looked at Catra's hand around her wrist. Light moved through her fingers, faint and unbidden, gold tracing the lines of her palm, then fading. Even standing down had not been enough. The magic still knew what she was.

Adora let Catra pull her towards the bed. The mattress dipped under her weight, too soft, too forgiving. She dragged the nearest blanket around her shoulders and pulled it tight, winding her arms around her torso, trying to hold herself together.

Catra climbed onto the bed beside her, close but not crowding.

"The ceremony," Adora said. "The surge at the ceremony. I was standing there and everyone cheered and I didn't know what I'd done. And now I know.”

“You were there,” Catra said. “But you didn’t do anything.”

“My being there made it worse.”

Catra’s hand tightened around the edge of her own blanket, then loosened deliberately. “Entrapta’s data showed a connection with She-Ra’s presence…”

“My presence. She-Ra is me.”

At least She-Ra had been her. Now Etheria might be safer if she stayed away from the places that needed help.

Catra was quiet for a moment. "The surges were happening before you responded to them."

"They were smaller before I responded to them."

A beat. "Yes," Catra said. "They were."

She didn't try to argue around it. Adora had expected her to and she hadn't, and that was harder to hold than an argument would have been.

“The Fright Zone earlier. The magic answered She-Ra and the walkway cracked and split and people had to run."

"People got out," Catra said.

"Because I held it long enough. Not because I fixed it. Entrapta said…”

"Entrapta said the connection is amplifying something. She didn't say you're wrong and bad and deserve to be…” Catra stopped. Her jaw set. "I'm not doing this anymore tonight."

Adora went rigid.

Catra scrubbed both hands over her face. “Not this. I’m not going through your list when you’ve already decided what every answer means. Just stop. You don't have to sleep. But you need to rest. You’re staying in this bed, and I'm not helping you put yourself on trial all night.”

They fell into a strained silence. Adora listened to Catra's breathing gradually slow and watched the darkness thicken beyond the balcony. She lay still, her own thoughts circling while she kept herself from restarting the conversation, knowing Catra wouldn't participate. The list kept trying to grow backward. She didn’t remember closing her eyes.

When she opened them, she felt heavy, disoriented. The room was darker. The clouds outside had thickened, choking out the

moons. Catra was slumped beside her, one hand still curled near Adora’s knee, as if she’d fallen asleep mid-gesture.

Nothing had changed while she slept. Adora had hoped sleep might loosen the thought, make it smaller. Instead, it had sunk deeper, beyond argument. The answer felt settled now. Sleep hadn’t undone the knowing.

She slipped out from under the blanket. The floor was cold. She started to pace again. The recent mistakes bled into older ones until the memories no longer stayed neatly separate. The ledger had no beginning that she could find.

Catra blinked wearily, shifting across the bed toward her. Catra was still right here with her.

“I left you,” Adora whispered.

The waterfall stopped. Only for a heartbeat.

Then it resumed harder, full and relentless, the sound becoming almost overwhelming.

Catra went still. “Adora…”

“I told myself it was the right choice, but it hurt you.”

Catra’s jaw tightened. “It hurt. I'm not going to tell you it didn't."

The honesty landed harder than comfort would have. Shame filled her until she could barely breathe, and still it did not undo the damage, did not make her better, did not tell her what to do next. Some part of her kept searching for a cost large enough to balance it, some punishment that would finally make up for all the harm she had done and kept doing without even meaning to do it.

“But you don’t get to use me as proof that you ruin everything.”

Catra closed her hand around Adora’s. Adora could not make herself return the pressure, but she didn’t pull away. She let Catra

guide her back to the bed.

She had wanted proof that she was good. She had thought trying harder, helping more, controlling herself would eventually give her that. None of it had. Now there was proof of something else, something all her trying had failed to prevent. Adora could not find doubt in the verdict.

Catra did not tell her she was innocent. She stayed as though innocence had never been the price of being loved. Catra’s hand remained around hers, warm and stubborn. Adora lay rigid for a long time, then eased almost imperceptibly, and let that be true.

Chapter 13: Choice

Chapter Summary

Adora doesn’t trust herself to know, so what will she choose?

Dawn came thin and quiet, the kind of stillness that felt borrowed. The waterfall continued its low rush. Catra’s hand was warm around hers, fingers loosely covering, anchoring her to the bed even though her mind kept wandering.

It had been a long night. Adora’s thoughts kept circling the same impossible questions. If she couldn’t prove she was good, erase the harm she did, or punish herself into feeling okay, what could she actually do?

Her heart sped up, too fast for how still she was lying. Beside her, Catra stirred immediately, as if she’d been waiting for it. A blue eye blinked open, then gold, both focusing with concerned attention.

“I’m scared.” Adora’s voice was barely more than a breath. “I don’t know what the right thing is. I don’t trust myself to know.”

“Okay.” Catra’s voice was rough with sleep but steady. Her thumb brushed once across Adora’s knuckles. “Then don’t know. I’m still here.” Catra’s tail curled protectively around her ankle.

The tracker pad chimed from the shelf.

Catra’s ears flicked back. She reached for it without letting go of Adora’s hand, her eyes narrowing as she read. “Etheria’s destabilizing. More than before. They want you in the War Room.”

Adora went still. She had stood down and accepted that she was the disruptive factor, the one causing the harm. Now the magic was surging worse.

The edges of the room felt distant. The magical hum underneath everything became more noticeable. The light and sound around her disconnected from her for a moment.

She knew the feeling, Etheria's magic. She was scared. She was still here. She grounded herself by pressing her feet firmly against the cool floor. The magic thrummed through her, but she stayed present.

There was no doubt that She-Ra had affected the magic, but maybe standing down was not enough to fix it.

"Okay. Let's go."

They dressed quickly and headed down the polished hall, their footsteps too loud. The castle felt hushed as early morning light rose over the grounds and the blue blur of the Woods in the distance. The hum of Etheria threaded through the stone, through her ribs, everywhere. She kept walking.

They entered the War Room where the full alliance had once again gathered. Catra's shoulder brushed against hers. The map throbbed with red. Bright Moon sat in a pool of gold, but amber bled outward in every direction, dissolving into a sea of red markers.

Adora tore her gaze from the map and looked at the weary faces around her. Mermista's arms were crossed. Frosta's jaw was set. Glimmer looked like she hadn't slept much either.

She started to speak, "I don't know what will happen if I transform again. I don't know if it will make things better or worse." She straightened her shoulders. "But maybe not being She-Ra is also wrong. Because I'm connected to Etheria." She paused. "I want to work together." Catra's tail curled around her calf. "Not because I'm sure it will work. Because I can't figure it out alone. I need you with me."

Mermista looked somewhat skeptical. "And if She-Ra does make it worse?"

Catra’s tail tightened for a moment then eased.

“Then we’ll adjust,” Adora said. “We plan and monitor and change course when needed.” Adora swallowed. “I don't think I should go in there alone and decide what Etheria needs. But I don't think staying away is helping either.”

Glimmer looked at the map then at Adora. Her expression settled. “Okay,” she said. “Let's figure out what everyone can contribute.”

They went around the table. Perfuma could feel root systems. She would be in contact via tracker pad from Plumeria's border and provide information on what the roots were doing. Entrapta could track the surge readings from her lab in Dryl and flag when the intensity shifted. Swift Wind would stick with She-Ra. He could sense the magical resonance through the bond.

Mermista would watch how the surges moved through Salineas’ waterways. Frosta would monitor ice cracks and physical instability in the Kingdom of Snows. Bow and Glimmer would coordinate communication between everyone from the War Room. The guards could manage evacuation and physical logistics. Catra insisted she was staying by Adora’s side.

“Entrapta, can you tell me when the readings become dangerous?” Adora asked.

“I can tell you when they change, but not necessarily what dangerous means,” Entrapta clarified.

Adora nodded. She listened to what each person offered and agreed. She didn't reshape their contributions toward a plan she'd already formed.

As their voices wove, Etheria’s magic had become just a low hum in the background. The map looked different by the end of the meeting. Not less red. The red was still there, the damage was still real. Now the markers showed them where help was needed, where to watch, where to respond.

Adora didn't need the map to tell her everything. She just needed it to tell her enough to take the next step. She wasn't certain any of this would work, but it was something they could try.

…

Swift Wind landed at the edge of the Whispering Woods as the morning light came fully over the hills. They headed in at a gallop, Catra seated in front of Adora on his back. The path through the Woods narrowed, the canopy thickening overhead until the light came through in thin, green-tinged shafts.

Distances began to feel strange, the dark trunks blurring together then suddenly sharp. Her focus jumped too quickly from a clump of twisting trees to a wary creature's peering gaze to a large crack splitting the ground. Adora felt her pulse blending into the rhythm of Etheria.

"It's getting stronger," she said, her voice thin.

Swift Wind's ears twitched. One wing shifted back until the feathers brushed Adora's leg.

Catra's hand found hers immediately, fingers threading through and squeezing. "Still here."

The words sounded too far away. She-Ra's magic rose beneath her skin, gold flickering up her fingers and arms. She was suddenly breathless. Her heart raced, and her hands trembled.

Adora focused on the light touch of Catra's claws against her palm, the solid warmth of her, the faint vibration of Swift Wind's hooves on the ground. She felt the rhythms of their breathing and matched them. The sensations didn't ease, but she felt held through them.

Adora climbed down, her eyes darting to each new movement. The air tasted electric. Vines grew in several directions. The path had cracked in jagged lines, some wide enough to swallow a boot.

Pulses moved through the ground in waves. Which part was wrong? What needed to stop? There wasn't one clean place.

“It feels tight. Like everything is pulling against everything else,” Swift Wind said.

The tracker pad on Catra’s belt chimed.

Catra held it up, splitting her attention between the screen and Adora’s face. “Perfuma says the roots are bracing. Holding on for dear life, her words. And Entrapta…” She tilted the pad so Adora could see the spike of data, jagged and nearly red. “Intensity is increasing. She says she can tell you how much but not what.”

Adora looked at the chaos again. The fractures were spreading faster now, the ground shivering. She looked at Catra. Gold and blue eyes, steady and fierce. Her hand was wrapped around Adora’s, her thumb pressing hard into the center of her palm.

“Okay. I’m going to transform now.” Adora stepped forward.

Swift Wind shifted his weight, hooves digging into the broken dirt. His ears pinned back, but he stayed beside her.

Adora’s hands shook slightly as her voice reached for her power. “For the honor of Grayskull.” Light blazed from her hands, surrounded her, brightening as she grew.

Entrapta’s readings jumped.

Perfuma’s voice over the comm, “I felt the roots shift.”

Swift Wind’s horn glowed. His forelegs stiffened.

The hum beneath her skin seemed enormous. The Woods, which were distant and wrong moments before, now felt frighteningly close. Every leaf, every root, every panicked heartbeat of every creature pressed against her awareness.

She staggered. Catra caught her elbow. Her ears had flattened completely, but when Adora found her face, Catra held her gaze. Swift Wind made a low, worried sound and crowded closer on Adora's other side.

"It's even stronger," Adora said. She closed her eyes. That made it worse, the input flooding in without the anchor of sight. She opened them again, fixing on Catra's face, on Swift Wind's eyes, on the cracked ground that still needed her. She took a moment, just one breath, then another.

"Okay," she said. A pause. "What are we looking at?"

They worked it collectively. Entrapta flagged where the readings were highest. Perfuma described what the root systems were doing. Swift Wind told her where the resonance felt most strained.

They found a place where the pressure seemed most concentrated. She-Ra moved toward it. The ground there had buckled into a low ridge, roots knotted so tight the dirt looked woven, and the air above it shimmered.

She looked at her hands. They were glowing, steady with She-Ra's light, and they were the same hands that had left gold markers bleeding into amber across a map. They trembled, but she opened her palms and reached outward. She released light into the compressed knot of magic, making room for the pressure to breathe.

The ridge eased by a fraction. The shimmering air settled. Relief flickered in her chest.

"Whatever you just did, the surge here dropped…" Mermista's voice crackled through the tracker pad on Catra's belt. Then static. "Wait. No. It's moving east."

Magic shot through weakened ground in a visible gold-white ripple. An enormous root jerked upward, tearing a tree sideways, crashing into the underbrush. A high, thin cry followed, an animal noise, sharp and terrified.

Adora’s vision darkened at the edges. She had done that. She looked at her too-large, glowing hands.

Beside her, Catra flinched at the crash. Her tail puffed once before lashing low behind her.

Swift Wind wheeled toward Adora, one wing sweeping out between her and the damage.

The ground beneath Adora’s boots felt suddenly distant. The hum in her bones became a roar, indistinguishable from her own pulse. The animal’s cry stretched into a thin whine she couldn’t locate.

She had to fix it. Now. Adora shoved more light into the ground, desperately trying to force the Woods back into shape. Her hands were shaking worse now, and the light came in uncontrolled flickers.

The fractures around her widened. Another root snapped upward, whipping past her shoulder. The magic spiraled, feeding on her panic and shame. Each surge made her more afraid, each fear making the surge stronger.

Catra’s hand hovered between Adora and the buckling ground. Then she grabbed Adora’s arm. “Adora!” Catra’s voice, sharp beside her. “Adora, look at me. Look at my face. You’re here. You’re right here. Don’t disappear into it.”

Adora couldn’t find her eyes. The darkness was closing in.

Swift Wind pawed hard at the dirt, eyes fixed on Adora. Through the bond came a sharp pulse of fear that wasn’t hers.

“Stop trying to fix everything at once!” Catra’s voice cracked on the last word. She was closer now, right in front of Adora, but her voice sounded like it was coming through water. “You’re not the only one here. Adora. Adora.”

“I can't…” Her hands were shaking. “I moved it wrong, I didn't account for…”

Catra’s ears twitched toward the animal’s cry. “Swift Wind.” Catra's voice cut across. “What's happening to the creature?”

Swift Wind was already turning toward the sound, wings tight against his sides as he picked his way over the fractured ground. His voice broke through her haze, “It’s trapped! Over here.”

The creature was trapped. That’s what was happening right now. It needed her. The darkness stopped encroaching and began to clear. The Woods sharpened again before her. Adora dragged in a breath.

The magic all around them still surged. The ground was cracking apart. She focused on the creature. On Catra, the coolness of claws against the heat of the magic. She couldn't get lost in it. Not now.

She crossed to the fallen tree and got her hands under the trunk, She-Ra's hands, too large and capable of more than she'd asked them to be. She lifted carefully. Catra was already there, moving low and fast, finding the creature and guiding it free. It was stone gray with a flicker of blue, reptilian with ear frills. It ran the moment it could, all six feet scrambling through the undergrowth until it was gone.

Swift Wind’s eyes followed it. His wings lowered slowly, though his ears stayed angled toward Adora.

She-Ra stood with the displaced trunk still in her hands. She set it down slowly and turned back to the surge. She didn't know how to fix all of this. Her heart beat fast.

The tracker pad crackled. “Adora,” Entrapta’s voice came, high and bright with focus, “the pressure didn't disappear, it moved. Some of it travelled along an existing fracture without creating more pressure.”

Perfuma’s voice followed, gentle but threaded with strain. “The roots want to flex. They’re trying to find room.”

Bow came through next. “I’ve got it on the map. The drop in the Woods lines up with the spike Mermista saw east of Salineas. It’s not disappearing. It’s shifting between regions.”

“Then nobody follows the pressure alone,” Glimmer said. “Report changes before you compensate for them. We move together.”

Adora looked at Catra. Catra’s ears were forward, her eyes sharp, her hand hovering near Adora’s elbow, ready.

“Okay,” Adora said. Her voice was rough. “Let’s try something small.”

She-Ra knelt, hesitated for a moment, and then placed one palm against the buckled ground. A thin thread of light trembled out from her hand into the dirt and roots. She felt a small resistance and stopped.

Perfuma hummed softly into the comm. “The roots near the fractures aren’t bracing as hard. Maybe the cracks can carry the movement if we don’t fight them.”

Adora adjusted her position closer to the fracture and released a little more light, making space toward the crack.

“Still tracking,” Entrapta said. “No secondary spikes.”

Swift Wind called out, “It feels loose, flowing. Keep giving it paths.”

Another area eased. The magic shifted, unexpected, sliding sideways instead of forward. She almost tried to redirect it, but instead she stopped.

“Hold there,” Frosta said over the tracker. “We’ve got an echo of pressure fracturing here.” Frosta came back after a moment. “Okay. It stopped spreading. The ice settled. You can keep going.”

Adora exhaled. She hadn’t realized she’d been holding her breath. She let her magic flow, easing it toward a crack.

She was deep in it now. The hum beneath her skin pulsated with competing rhythms, all of it pressing against her awareness. She could feel every shift, every tremor, every place where the magic wanted to tear instead of flow. She started scanning every shift for signs she was causing another disaster, that her hands were destroying instead of healing. She felt herself searching for the one signal that would tell her what was safe.

Her hands tightened, the light flickered. She recognized it. She reached out. Her fingers found Catra's wrist and gripped. "I can't tell what I'm doing anymore," she said. The words scraped out, thin and frightened. "I can't tell if I'm helping or…"

Catra swallowed. Her gaze flicked toward the glowing fractures, then back to Adora. She didn't look certain either. Catra turned her hand over and laced their fingers together. "Then don't tell. Ask."

She turned to Swift Wind, "What do you feel now?"

Swift Wind's ears lifted toward her. Some of the tension left his wings before he answered. "It feels alive, looser than before. Moving."

Adora nodded and closed her eyes. She felt Catra's steady heartbeat through her hand, the feel of the bond with Swift Wind, the rhythm of voices over the comm, and the magic of Etheria. She felt them, all of them, distinct rhythms, responsive and alive.

Etheria's magic, no longer one overwhelming roar, but many movements. Some were pressing, some releasing, some flowing, some holding. They were responsive to each other, some rhythms crossing, some resisting, some settling when another shifted.

Together they guided the pressure along existing fractures. Certain roots needed support to flex. Sometimes more of She-Ra's magic was needed, and sometimes she needed to stop touching.

"Where else do you need me?" Adora asked into the comm.

There was a pause while Bow checked the map. “Hold where you are. Plumeria’s easing. Salineas is steady. Frosta’s side is still settling.”

Glimmer added, “Stay with the Woods for now. We’ll tell you if that changes.”

They worked slowly. A push here. A stop there. A hold while the magic found its own path. Adora’s hands moved by inches, by fractions, guided by voices and bond and touch.

The ground settled. The roots stopped wrenching themselves apart. The frantic pulses eased into something slower, something that breathed.

Entrapta’s voice came over the comm. “The runaway resonance is dropping. It’s… it’s stabilizing. Not fixed, but no longer exponential.”

The hum of the magic diminished, no longer too tight, more like a soft current, flowing. Adora sat back on her heels, exhausted. Catra’s hand was still in hers, sweaty and warm.

The Woods looked different. There were cracks in the ground, jagged and raw. Within them, new green growth had pushed through. The dark trunk that had fallen lay across the ground, its roots exposed to the air, but already smaller plants were threading through the wreckage, using it. A winged creature, not quite a bird, settled on a branch. The Woods had been changed and hurt, but Etheria was no longer tearing itself apart.

Glimmer’s voice came through the tracker, “Adora, where do you need the guards to help now?”

She looked around the Woods, seeing a mix of damage and change. “The eastern path needs to be cleared so that supplies can still get to Moorlet.”

Catra was beside her. Adora was staring at a place where their intervention cracked the ground and growth was moving slowly

beneath it.

Catra noticed she'd gone still. “What do you see?”

Adora looked again. “The roots keep moving.”

Catra waited.

Adora watched them. They weren’t surging now, just unhurriedly finding their way through the newly opened ground. “We should make sure they have room.”

Chapter 14: Repair

Chapter Summary

Etheria is still changing. Adora is too.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The map had stopped asking for everything at once. For a few quiet days in a row, its lines had held steady, their glow soft and even. They traced an Etheria that had changed and was still slowly changing.

Bow stood across from Adora, sorting reports into two uneven stacks while Glimmer leaned beside him, reading one from Perfuma on the recovered root system. Catra had claimed the edge of the table nearest Adora, close enough for the occasional sweep of her tail to brush Adora's boot. She was eating a piece of fruit and nudging a report toward whichever of them it belonged to as needed. Adora glanced at one, her fingers curled around a ceramic mug, imperfectly glazed in mismatched colors.

“Hey Arrow Boy, you’re spreading again.” Catra lifted an eyebrow. “Contain yourself.”

Bow slid one whole pile a few inches back, then went searching for the stylus that had rolled under the reports. Glimmer suppressed a smile and took a sip of her tea.

Bow retrieved the stylus and pointed out over the Woods on the map, “So, the magic has stabilized. There’s damage, but no more surges.”

“It’s settled,” Glimmer agreed. She leaned casually against the table. “The guards’ reports and Entrapta’s readings all show that growth is consistent with the post-Heart patterns again. It’s still changing, but normally now.”

Adora traced a finger along the edge of the table. She could still feel a faint hum in the air. The magic was there. It would always be there, but it was no longer pressing and overwhelming. "Normal," she repeated, testing the word.

Bow reached for the next report and knocked another sideways. Adora's hand moved automatically.

Catra got there first, pinning the corner with one claw and sliding it neatly back into place. "Crisis averted," Catra said.

Glimmer gave Bow a look. "The Alliance survives another paperwork surge."

Bow pressed a hand to his chest. "Barely."

Adora lowered her hand back to her mug. No one needed her to fix the stack. The report was only a report.

Bow patted the top of one stack, then the other. His brow furrowed. "Where did the Crimson Waste note go?"

"Under your elbow," Glimmer said.

Bow lifted his elbow. There was nothing there.

Catra, without looking up from her fruit, nudged a folded report across the table with two fingers.

Adora felt her mouth twitch before she could stop it.

Bow retrieved the report with as much dignity as he could manage. "There's a new marker," he said, his voice a little too bright, trying to be casual even as he said something he knew was loaded. An amber marker materialized. "An energy signature in the Crimson Waste. Low-level. Maybe settling."

Adora's body reacted. Her spine straightened, shoulders squaring. Her hand twitched. She leaned toward it before she realized she'd decided anything. Her mind began to race forward, already

assembling a mission and the arguments for why she should go now. She wondered whether Swift Wind was available.

She needed more information. Was it at all similar to the prior surges? She needed to be there, eyes on it, controlling the variables. She wanted the full report in her hands. She wanted to stand in the Waste and feel any wrongness with her own two feet.

“Adora.” Glimmer’s voice was gentle, her eyes steady. “We’ll know more tomorrow. It’s not an urgent reading.”

Adora’s gaze dropped back to the map. Her fingers curled against her palm. She could feel the pull, like if she just leaned toward it, she could outrun the fear for one more day. She let herself want it. She also felt Catra’s attention, knew she’d stopped reading supply requisitions.

Adora looked over. Blue and gold eyes fixed on her, unblinking in the bright crystal light of the room. Catra didn’t say stop or you’re doing it again. She just returned Adora’s gaze. Adora exhaled slowly. Her shoulders lowered in a hard-won release.

“Tomorrow,” Adora said, and her voice didn’t shake.

Catra’s tail brushed her boot once, deliberate this time.

Glimmer nodded and returned to her tea and the root report.

Adora set her mug down, and the ceramic clinked softly.

Catra tilted her head toward the door.

Adora looked at the map once more, the steady lines of Etheria and the soft amber glow of a low, unknown energy reading that could mean something or nothing, and they wouldn't know more until tomorrow. The crisis was over. Etheria's magic was still alive.

She caught Catra’s eye, held it, and walked toward the door with her. The marker remained on the map. Adora walked away anyway.

…

There were cracks running through the gardens, a split path, a tree leaning strangely beside it. Some cracks had been left open because new growth had found them and was coming up through. Adora walked past without speaking, Catra beside her, close enough that their shoulders almost brushed.

Adora believed she had made the choices she needed to make. It had worked, and it had broken things. The nearest crack was open enough to show the dark strata beneath Bright Moon's cultivated beauty, dirt and root and the faint glint of residual magic. Adora looked at it.

Catra stopped beside her, following her gaze. “Overheard the gardeners saying the star-lilies are growing blue now.”

“Blue,” Adora repeated.

“They seemed excited about the change.”

Adora nodded. The world had not gone back to how it was. There was damage still to be fixed and things they still didn’t understand. That was what came next, not a verdict.

She started walking again, Catra falling into step beside her, comfortable in a silence that didn't need filling with chatter. They passed a section of wall, broken and blackened in a starburst pattern.

Guards were working beside gardeners, passing stones and sacks of mortar in a line that moved with an easy rhythm. Adora watched a young guard laugh at something a gardener said, then set a stone into the damaged wall at the wrong angle. The gardener squinted, shook their head, and tapped it loose again. The guard winced, but the gardener only handed it back and showed them how to turn it. Nearby, two others adjusted the supports around the leaning tree, loosening one line and tying it lower until the trunk settled into a steadier lean.

Stopping the surge hadn't saved the wall. Saving the wall hadn't been the choice available to her then. Repairing it was the choice available now. There had been no place she could have stood that would have kept everything whole. She had wanted so badly for there to have been a way.

She did not know, still, whether the marker in the Crimson Waste would be the start of something or the end of nothing. She did not know if the blue star-lilies were beautiful or a warning. She did not know if the faint hum would fade or grow, if there would come a day when she reached and found she had reached too hard, too far, too much. She wished she knew. The wishing was a constant beneath her thoughts, the desire for a map that showed not just where they were but where they would be safe.

She was still scared of what happened when she couldn't prevent harm. The fear stayed with her, waxing and waning instead of filling the whole sky. The world had cracked open and kept going.

Near the side of the path, one of the star-lilies had opened between two fractured stones, its petals an unfamiliar blue. Adora looked at it. She didn't know what the change meant. They passed, and she let it be blue.

They reached the garden's edge, where the damage gave way to wild growth. The grounds were recovering and also becoming something new. Adora stopped.

Catra's hand found hers, their fingers interlacing. Adora squeezed back. They turned away from the broken lawn, from the guards and gardeners still working, and all the things they did not yet understand. They walked back toward the castle.

The walk to their rooms was unhurried. There was nowhere else they needed to go. The corridors were mostly empty. Adora did not turn toward the War Room to check the map one last time, or send a message, or make a list. She did not pause at the threshold. She simply followed Catra inside their room.

When Catra sprawled onto the bed, Adora lay beside her. Adora heard the rush of the waterfall and let it flow without overwhelming her. The crystals caught the light and turned it into shimmers of color on the walls. Outside, the breeze scattered blue petals along the balcony rail.

She thought of the marker in the Waste. She felt the old pull toward action, toward solving, toward outrunning the fear. The image came, and she let it stay without reaching for it.

"You seem lighter," Catra said.

Adora saw the careful softness Catra tried so often to hide. "I think I am," she said, surprised by how uncertain and true it felt.

Catra's ears slowly lifted. For a moment, the relief showed. Catra's exhale came slow. Adora's next breath matched.

For so long, Adora had been trying to find where to stand. She realized she didn't need to know. Goodness was a choice made in motion, not a static patch of ground she had to find and defend.

Adora reached for Catra's hand. Her fingers caught briefly at Catra's wrist before finding their way into hers. Adora rested her weight into Catra's side.

She could stand with the people she loved and belong there. She could be ready to repair whatever the right choices couldn't save.

The scent of blossoms drifted from the balcony, faint and sweet. A blue petal had caught in Catra's hair. Adora brushed it free.

Things didn't need to be fine. Tomorrow, the cracks would still be there. Morning light would gather in the chipped edges of the balcony tiles all over again.

Adora curled into Catra and settled into the unguarded quiet.



Chapter End Notes

A lot of this story grew from my questioning how to be a good person when even the best intentions sometimes cause harm. I started thinking about how Adora might feel similarly especially because I relate so strongly to the patterns of needing to anticipate, control, and be responsible for everything that she also seems to have developed as a child. Those patterns can become so deeply ingrained that even when they are harming more than helping, they can still feel almost impossible to stop.

Then came the idea of Etheria's magic reflecting and amplifying Adora's internal emotional truths, forcing what she would normally try to deal with on her own out into the world around her. I wasn't sure where the ideas would take me when I started, but I'm really pleased with where the story ended up.

I also hope my explorations of these topics can help others feel a little less alone in whatever versions of them they carry.

Thanks for reading! I'll certainly be exploring more of life's questions through my fav SPOP characters soon.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!